

Why Is This Still Here?

How Things Go from Selling Out to Never Leaving



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How to Read This Book

◆ **This book uses three sets of words, and that's all**

Everything you need before starting is on this page.

Three clocks — they tell you where you are now.

Clock	Cycle	What sits on it
The fashion clock	Months	Whatever is being talked about
The generation clock	Ten to thirty years	The taste of one generation
The need clock	It doesn't move	Cold. Hungry. Sleep. A gift to give

Four bridges — they tell you where you can go.

Bridge	The question
Repeat	When it's used up, do you buy it again?
Shape	Do people recognize it without being told?
Patina	Does time add value or take it away?
Handoff	Does it pass to the next person?

Four paths — they tell you what happened so far.

	Still here	Gone
It broke out	② Broke out and stayed	① Broke out and vanished
It didn't	③ Arrived late	— Never recorded

There is one more path that doesn't fit the table.

④ Sat quietly for a long time, then suddenly broke out.

Three sets of words. That's the whole apparatus. Part One builds them one at a time.

◆ **The shape of the book**

Part	What it covers	Format
Part One (1–4)	The two successes are different work	Concepts
Part Two (5–7)	Broke out and vanished	Autopsy
Part Three (8–10)	Broke out and stayed	Autopsy
Part Four (11–13)	Arrived late	Chronicle
Part Five (14–15)	Sat, then broke out	Chronicle
Part Six (16–20)	So what do you make?	Checklists

The format changes from part to part for a reason.

When the same format repeats twenty times, the reader stops reading the content and starts reading the procedure.

◆ **Where the names are, and where they aren't**

This book has one rule worth stating up front.

Part One and Part Six contain no company names and no product names.

Names age.

A name everybody knows today will need a footnote in ten years, and an example that needs a footnote slows the argument instead of helping it.

Part One builds the tools. Part Six lists the work. **Both need to age more slowly than anything else here.**

Names appear from Part Two through Part Five — **only where evidence is needed.**

And the names of things that were popular recently appear **only in Part Two**. That part is about things that vanished, so a name going stale there helps the argument rather than hurting it.

If someone opens this book years from now, reads Chapter 5, and asks "what was that?" — **the question itself is the proof of that part**.

The opening and closing follow the same rule. The two shops in them are not named in the text; **they are named in the sources at the end of the opening**.

◆ Numbers and sources

One rule.

A number that couldn't be verified doesn't go in.

Where a number is needed, this book first records which source would settle it. Anything that couldn't be

confirmed was **cut whole** rather than softened.

A hedged sentence gets read as a fact.

So a few passages give a direction rather than a figure. And Chapters 13 and 15 contain no names at all. In both, putting a name in would have meant writing something unverifiable as if it were verified.

◆ Three things this book does not promise

One, it does not promise a method for making a bestseller. Luck matters a great deal. Only the odds are covered here.

Two, it does not say that if you hold on, you eventually break out. Chapter 15 proves the opposite first.

Three, it keeps saying that only survivors were studied. No list exists of the things that never sold and quietly disappeared.

A book that overstates is old in three years. Overstating while claiming to write something durable doesn't hold together.

◆ **How to read it**

In order, or one part at a time. Each chapter stands on its own.

If you're in a hurry, the **short version table** at the end of each chapter is enough. Twenty of those tables laid end to end make the map of this book.

Two requests.

One, read both chapters of Part Five in one sitting.

Chapter 14 alone turns that part into comfort. Comfort makes a person feel better and changes nothing.

Two, write down at least one line at each chapter's end.

Every chapter closes with **One Line Today**. Read it and shut the book and nothing stays.

All of them are sized to be done today.

Opening — Five Hundred Stores, a Thousand Years

◆ Five hundred in two years

There was a dessert franchise.

It sold fruit coated in hardened sugar, on a skewer. At some point it spread everywhere. Every street had one. People queued.

Two years after the franchise began, the company announced its **five hundredth store**.¹

Seven months later there were four hundred and ninety.¹

Not more. Fewer.

In one three-month stretch that following spring and early summer, **a hundred and twenty-seven** shops in that category closed across the country.²

The closing rate climbed every month. Eleven in one month, twenty-eight two months later, forty-nine the month after.²

It took seven months from the party for the five hundredth store.

◆ One thing for a thousand years

There is another shop.

It sits on the approach road to a shrine in Kyoto, Japan, and it sells one thing: grilled rice cakes.³

It has been in that spot since around the year 1000.³

The person running it now is the **twenty-fifth generation**.³

The most striking thing about this shop is not what it sells. **It's what it doesn't do.**

No counter in a department store. No stalls at events. No added items. No branches.

The family's explanation is simple. **The policy is not to make the business bigger.**³

And why the shop exists at all contains everything this book is about.

There is a shrine in front of it, and people come to pray there.³

Worshippers come every year. And every year they are different people. That flow has not broken in a thousand years.

◆ Put the two numbers side by side

Five hundred, and a thousand.

The first is large. The second is slow. The first took two years to make. The second took a thousand.

Here is the question people usually ask.

Which one was better at business?

That this question is wrong is where this book starts.

Put the two on one line and no answer comes out. One earned a lot and one earned for a long time, and those are not values you can compare.

They are not better and worse at the same work.

They were doing different work.

One sold **what people were talking about.** The other sold **what people keep needing.**

Talk ends. Need doesn't.

So one earned a lot and finished, and the other earns a little and hasn't finished.

◆ What this book does

Two things.

One, it separates the two.

It pulls apart two words people use interchangeably. Once they're apart, you can see which one you're building.

The same object, handled as one or the other, produces opposite decisions. When to add locations and when adding locations kills you. When you have to keep advertising and when you don't have to at all.

What that franchise got wrong was not adding stores. **It was adding stores without knowing which one it was.**

Two, it builds a bridge from one side to the other.

This is the real content of the book.

Trace back the things that sell steadily now and something odd appears.

Most of them were not built to last.

They were once a huge topic of conversation. Everybody talked about them. And everything else that was talked about at the same time is gone.

They changed lanes at some point.

Where that change happens is what this book is trying to teach.

◆ This book does not take a side

One thing, stated before we start.

It does not say that lasting is right and flaring is wrong.

Breaking out big gives you things no other method gives. It's fast, people learn you exist, and sometimes it is the entrance to the lasting kind.

Breaking out is not the problem.

**Preparing only to break out, and not deciding
where to go after — that's the problem.**

What those queued-up shops got wrong was not making people queue. **It was changing nothing while the queue was there.**

◆ **Who this is for**

It was written for people who make something and sell it. A shop, an object, a piece of writing, anything being started.

But it isn't only for them.

**Anyone curious about why the things they own are still
in their hands** can read it.

This book measures books and clothes and appliances and food and film and music with the same ruler. A ruler where thermal underwear and a book on raising a child land in the same column.

Once that ruler is in your hand you'll use it walking into a bookshop, opening a closet, standing in a kitchen.

◆ **The conclusion, stated early**

This book has one conclusion.

Holding it back for the last chapter would be more fun.

It's more useful to read knowing it.

Most things that lasted were not planned. They just never disappeared.

That thousand-year-old shop did not start out planning a thousand years. It grilled rice cakes for people walking to a shrine.

And it never disappeared.

If that sentence is true, then anyone reading this book who has not broken out yet gains one advantage.

Never disappearing takes time rather than talent. And time can start being spent today.

That's what the last chapter is about.

◆ Sources for this opening

This book is careful with company names and product names in the text. Names age. The rule is spelled out in the next piece.

The opening follows the same rule, so nothing here is named. The names are recorded here so the claims can be checked.

1. The five-hundredth-store announcement and the store count seven months later, for a dessert franchise selling sugar-coated fruit skewers (Korean: *tanghulu*). To be confirmed against the company's own announcements and its franchise disclosure filings.
2. Closures across the whole category and the month-by-month trend. To be confirmed against the Korean

Ministry of the Interior and Safety's local business-permit data.

3. Ichiwa (Ichimonjiya Wasuke), the grilled rice cake shop on the approach to Imamiya Shrine in Kyoto: founding period, current generation, and the stated policy of not expanding. To be confirmed against the shop's own material and the Guinness World Records entry.

Part One • The Two Successes Are Different Work

◆ Starting without names

Four chapters.

Every tool this book uses comes out here. Three clocks, four bridges, and four paths.

Part One contains no company names and no product names.

That's deliberate. Names age.

A name everybody knows today will need explaining in ten years, and an example that needs explaining slows an argument instead of helping it.

Part One has to age more slowly than anything else in this book.

There's also no sources section in Part One. There are no numbers to check. Everything said here is about structure, and whether the structure holds gets tested by names starting in Part Two.

◆ **The order**

Chapter	The question
1	What is different about the two successes?
2	Different clocks run on different objects
3	The customers never come back. Why is it still open?
4	How many routes are there between staying and vanishing?

Chapter 1 separates the two. Chapter 2 builds the ruler that separates them. Chapter 3 shows how the lasting side actually works. Chapter 4 opens the map.

After four chapters you can pick up any object and describe it in this book's words. The remaining five parts are the process of checking whether those words hold.

Chapter 1 — Different Work: Selling Talk and Selling the Answer

◆ Two clocks run inside one bookshop

Walk into a bookshop and there's a table by the entrance.

Books lying face up, covers showing.

Most of what's on that table is gone in three months.

Twenty steps further in there are shelves. Books standing upright, only their spines showing.

Some of those have been in the same slot for ten years.

Twenty steps between the two places. And the books in those two places are **two different businesses.**

The shop **earns** from the entrance. It **survives** on the shelves.

Odd. Same building, same product. Why does it split in two?

◆ **The obvious reading — a steady seller is a bestseller that lasted**

The usual assumption: the especially good ones among the big sellers survive and turn into the long sellers.

Not even half right.

Some do survive. The proportion is low. And there's a more important fact underneath.

A large share of things that sell for a long time didn't sell at first.

The moment that sentence holds, you can no longer place the two on one line.

They are not the top and bottom of one ranking. **They are different exams.**

The two exams are marked differently, prepared for differently, and they pay out differently when you do well.

◆ **What a bestseller sells — talk**

Look closely at something selling in large numbers and it isn't only the object moving.

People are talking about it. To be in that conversation you have to have it.

What a bestseller sells is admission to the conversation.

This produces an unusual property.

The sales figure itself creates the demand.

Selling a lot becomes something to talk about, and that talk produces more sales. Past a certain point, a bestseller

runs by itself.

It ends for the same reason.

The value of talk falls when it repeats. To someone hearing the same story for the third time, the story is worth nothing.

And when the conversation ends, the reason to buy ends. The object is unchanged. The reason is gone.

A bestseller doesn't end because the product got old. It ends because the story got old.

◆ **What a steady seller sells — the answer**

Look at something that has sold for a long time and it usually isn't a conversation piece. Almost nobody talks about it.

It has a different property.

There is a fixed moment when not having it becomes a problem.

Winter arrives. A baby is born. Someone lives alone for the first time. A parent starts getting ill. Somebody manages people for the first time.

Those moments don't pick their people. **Every year the same moment arrives for someone new.**

A steady seller is standing in that moment.

It sells not because the object is being discussed, but because the moment came and the object was there.

A bestseller bets on what people are talking about.

A steady seller bets on when people get stuck.

◆ **The curves are different**

Put the two sales curves side by side and the shapes are nothing alike.

A bestseller is a peak. Steep up, steep down. Impressive height, narrow width.

A steady seller is a plain. You can't see it rising. Low, wide, and you can't tell when it started.

There's a miscalculation that happens here often.

Peaks are visible and plains are not. So the peak looks bigger.

The area is often larger on the plain.

The trouble is that you can only know that **ten years later**. So at the moment of deciding, the peak always looks bigger.

◆ **The costs move in opposite directions**

More important than the curves.

On a bestseller, cost grows with revenue.

Talk is the fuel. Cut the fuel and the fire goes out immediately. So you cannot stop promoting while it sells. You spend the most exactly when you sell the most.

On a steady seller, cost barely grows with revenue.

The buyer comes looking. You only have to be sitting in the place where the question gets asked, as the answer.

Stop promoting for a year and sales barely move. **This one sentence separates the profit margins of the two businesses.**

The same revenue leaves a different amount in your hand. And the gap widens with time.

◆ So is a bestseller a bad thing?

No. This book doesn't say that.

There are three things a bestseller gives you that nothing else does.

One, speed. It builds in three months what a plain takes ten years to build.

Two, visibility. People learn that the thing exists. However good it is, nothing happens while nobody knows it's there.

Three, it's also the entrance to becoming a steady seller.

Plenty of things that sell steadily now were once enormous topics of conversation. They didn't come down off the peak. **They moved across to the plain.**

All of Part Three is that story.

So the problem isn't aiming for a bestseller.

The problem is preparing only to finish at the front table, and not preparing to move to the shelves.

◆ **The short version**

	Bestseller	Steady seller
What it sells	Talk — admission to the conversation	The answer — in that moment
What creates demand	The sales figure itself	A situation that repeats
The customer	Whoever knows the story now	Whoever reached that situation this year
The more it sells	The talk wears out	The name hardens
Stop promoting	It goes out immediately	Very little changes
The curve	A tall narrow peak	A low wide plain
Why it ends	The conversation ended	The situation disappeared

Look at the last line once more.

A steady seller usually doesn't end because a better competitor arrived. **It ends when the situation it was standing in disappears.**

Part Two uses this distinction again. This sentence is the tool that sorts the vanished things into groups.

◆ One Line Today

Pick up three objects within arm's reach. Not the expensive ones — the near ones.

Write one line for each on why you bought it. Then mark it one of two ways.

- **Talk** — everyone was discussing it at the time
- **Answer** — something came up that required it

Then one last question.

Of the three, which ones do you still actually use?

The answers usually pile onto one side. **The side they pile onto is the side you should be building.**

Chapter 2 — Three Clocks: Fashion, Generation, Need

◆ Inside one house, the objects are different ages

The iron pan in the kitchen might be twenty years old.

The phone in your pocket is about two. The yogurt in the fridge is three days old and will be gone in three more.

All three were paid for. Their lifespans differ by a factor of a thousand.

It isn't price. The phone cost more than the pan. It isn't durability either. The phone usually gets replaced before it breaks.

Different clocks are running on different objects.

This chapter counts how many clocks there are. There are three.

◆ The obvious reading — make it well and it lasts

Quality decides lifespan.

Half right.

What quality decides is **how long the object holds up.**

What decides lifespan is **how long people keep wanting it.**

Every house has something that works perfectly and never gets used. It wasn't thrown out because it broke. It was put away because the wanting stopped.

So the question changes.

Not "how long will this hold up" but "how long will the wanting hold up."

That wanting has three cycles.

◆ One · The fashion clock — months

This clock runs on **what other people are doing right now.**

So the cycle is short. The moment everyone has it, it stops being worth having.

Things on the fashion clock share one trait.

They're no fun to own alone.

The value isn't inside the object. It's in your relation to everyone else. When everyone else loses interest, what's in your hand loses value too.

Objects on this clock make money fast. And nobody knows when they'll stop.

Not knowing when it stops is the single decisive risk of this clock.

◆ **Two · The generation clock — ten to thirty years**

Some things get into the body early. A familiar sound, a familiar taste, a familiar cut of clothing.

These don't turn over in months like fashion. They also aren't permanent.

They age as the people who learned them age.

The dangerous part is elsewhere.

**Anyone standing on this clock doesn't believe
they're standing on fashion.**

If you think it's fashion you prepare for it. If you think it's taste you don't.

It hasn't changed in over ten years, so it looks like it never will. That judgment is usually proved wrong in year fifteen.

The generation clock is **the easiest one to be fooled by.**

◆ Three · The need clock — it doesn't move

Cold. Hungry. Sleepy. Hurting. Bored. Lonely. Wanting to be seen. Wanting to pass something on.

This list was the same a hundred years ago. It probably won't differ much in another hundred.

This clock doesn't turn.

One qualification matters more than anything else on this page.

The need doesn't change. The method of meeting it does.

Keeping out the cold doesn't change. What you keep it out with keeps changing. Getting word to someone far away doesn't change. What you send it with has changed several times.

So sitting on the need clock requires care.

Grab the method and you go when the method goes.
Grab the need and you stay as long as the need stays.

That sentence comes back more often than any other in this book. It explains the vanished things in Part Two and the revived ones in Part Four.

◆ Inside one category, all three clocks are present

Here a common confusion clears up.

The category doesn't set the clock. Clothing isn't fashion because it's clothing; food isn't need because it's food.

All three clocks exist inside every category.

Category	Fashion clock	Generation clock	Need clock
Clothing	This season's silhouette	What a generation wore like a uniform	Thermal layers · socks

Category	Fashion clock	Generation clock	Need clock
Food	The dessert with the queue	The taste learned as a child	Staples · water · salt
Appliances	A newly introduced format	The kitchen a generation learned	Fire · water · cold · light
Media	The song of that summer	A generation's music and actors	Lullabies · holiday songs · old stories
Books	This year's talked-about title	A generation's standard works	Child-raising · dictionaries · scripture · cookbooks

Read the table across, not down.

Clothing and books are entirely different categories. But things in the same column behave the same way.

Thermal underwear and a book on raising a child sit on the same clock. Neither is ever advertised much. Neither has ever been a topic of conversation. Both sell every year.

The clock decides the fate of an object, not the category.

◆ **What happens when you misread the clock**

Two mistakes, pointing in opposite directions.

One. Making need-clock investments on a fashion-clock object.

Adding equipment, opening locations, buying things meant to last. When the talk ends the revenue is gone and the equipment isn't.

That mistake is Chapter 7. **It is the most common way to fail, and the most energetic.**

Two. Selling a need-clock object like fashion.

Pushing hard, changing it often, making limited editions.

The value of a need-clock object comes from **the fact that it doesn't change**. That what you bought last year and this year are the same thing is the asset.

Keep changing it and you're spending your own asset.

The first mistake loses money. **The second loses time**. And time can't be bought back.

◆ Clocks can be changed

That's the diagnosis. A diagnosis alone doesn't produce work.

Fortunately clocks aren't fixed.

Some things that started on the fashion clock moved to the need clock.

There are only four bridges across. Their names go here; how to use them is Part Three and Part Six.

Bridge	The question
Repeat	When it's used up, do you buy it again?
Shape	Do people recognize it without being told?
Patina	Does time add value or take it away?
Handoff	Does it pass to the next person?

Anything holding two or more of the four tends to last.

One is a season. None is a quarter.

◆ The short version

	Fashion clock	Generation clock	Need clock
Cycle	Months	Ten to thirty years	It doesn't turn
Runs on	What others are	The years you grew	The body and life

	Fashion clock	Generation clock	Need clock
	doing	up in	events
Value sits in	Your relation to others	Memory	The trouble of that moment
Biggest risk	You don't know when it stops	You don't know you're on fashion	Mistaking method for need
Stop promoting	It goes out at once	It fades slowly	Very little changes

The three clocks aren't good and bad. Deciding without knowing which one you're on is what's bad.

◆ One Line Today

Walk through the house and pick five objects. Include the oldest one and the newest one.

Beside each, write when you got it and which clock it's on.

Then one last question.

Will the newest one still be in this house in ten years?

If you answered yes, write one line on why you think so.

If what you wrote is one of the four bridges, the judgment is probably right.

Chapter 3 — Demand Doesn't Grow, It Renews

◆ **The shop whose customers never come back**

There's a shop that sells things for babies.

Customers usually come once and then stop coming after a few years. The child grows and there's nothing left to buy there.

Almost no regulars. The owner rarely has occasion to remember a face.

That shop has been in the same spot for twenty years.

The café across the street is the opposite. There are people who come every day and the owner knows their names.

The owner changes every few years.

Odd. The one with no regulars is still there. The one with regulars keeps closing.

◆ **The obvious reading — you need regulars to last**

Half right.

Regulars are good. **They aren't the condition for lasting.**

There's only one condition for lasting.

New customers keep appearing.

The same customers coming back is one way. Different customers coming is another way.

The second way is much less discussed. And most steady sellers live on the second way.

◆ **Two kinds of demand**

Demand comes in two kinds with different properties.

Demand that accumulates. Customers stay and add up.
This month's customers sit on top of last month's.

Demand that renews. Customers change over. This
month's customers are not last month's.

	Accumulating	Renewing
Customers	Pile up	Turn over
When it's going well	Grows fast	Doesn't grow
When it's going badly	Shrinks fast	Doesn't shrink
If you stop	They leak away	It stays the same
What it requires	Holding on to them	Still being there

The middle two rows are the point.

Accumulating demand has to grow to live. Stopping growth causes a problem. **Renewing demand doesn't shrink even though it doesn't grow.**

Not growing sounds like a flaw. It also means not falling.

◆ The door

Renewing demand doesn't appear just anywhere. It appears **where life repeats itself.**

This book calls those places **doors.**

Living alone for the first time. Starting work for the first time. A child being born. Managing people for the first time. A parent starting to get ill. Moving house.

These doors open every year. And every year **a different person** stands in front of one.

Whoever stands there has three things in common.

One, it's their first time, so they don't know. They can't choose for themselves, so they ask.

Two, they're in a hurry. The baby is already born and winter already came. They don't compare for long.

Three, being wrong is frightening. First time through, they don't know what's risky, so they pick the safe thing.

Put those three together and the nature of the competition changes completely.

At a door, the better thing does not win. The thing that comes to mind first wins.

◆ **Becoming the default**

This book calls the first-to-mind position **the default**.

It's an enormously strong position. It doesn't sell because it beat the competition; it sells because it is the answer.

And it has a strange property.

It can't be bought.

A default is not built by advertising. It's built by **what the people who already went through that door said.**

Whoever went first tells whoever comes next. Those remarks pile up, and then it's the default.

So it takes time. **And that is exactly why it's hard to take.**

A newcomer can build a better object. A newcomer cannot manufacture ten years of remarks from people who went ahead.

◆ **Why is such a good position empty?**

Worth stating plainly.

If the position is that good, why isn't everyone crowding into it?

Because it's boring.

Renewing demand doesn't explode. This year and next year look almost the same.

In numbers there's no growth rate. Nothing to announce, nothing to boast about.

People who put up money want to see something getting bigger. So that kind of money rarely arrives here.

This position isn't uncontested because the barrier is high. It's uncontested because it looks unappealing.

Hold on to that sentence. The last argument of this book, in Chapter 20, comes out of it.

Where large capital doesn't come, **whoever stayed longest wins**. And staying a long time costs less capital, not more.

◆ **When this demand ends**

Renewing demand ends too. It ends differently.

It rarely ends because a competitor beat it. **It ends because the door closes.**

It ends when people stop going through that situation. It also ends when they still go through it but stop solving it with your thing.

The sentence from the last chapter returns.

The need doesn't change; the method does.

Did the door close, or is the door open and something else became the answer? Telling those two apart is the work of Part Two.

So what a steady business checks each year is not the competition.

The question isn't "who is the competitor" but "is that door still open."

◆ **The short version**

Question	The answer for renewing demand
Who is the customer	Whoever stood at that door for the first time this year
Why do they buy	First time, in a hurry, afraid of being wrong
What wins	Not the better thing — the first thing to mind
How do you get that spot	Remarks from everyone who went through before
Why is it uncontested	It doesn't grow. It looks boring
When does it end	Not competition — when the door closes

◆ One Line Today

Think of something you did **for the first time** in the past year. It doesn't have to be large. First time is enough.

Write down what you bought then. Then write down how you found out about it.

- You saw an advertisement
- You searched
- **You asked a person**

Which of the three was it?

If you found out by asking a person, that thing currently holds the default position.

And one last question.

Is the thing you're making something people would tell each other about when one of them is doing something for the first time?

If not, you haven't found the door yet. **Finding a door takes time, not money.**

Chapter 4 — Four Paths: The Map of This Book

◆ Two lists that barely overlap

Take a sheet of paper and make two lists.

The first list. Ten things that sold enormously ten years ago.

Most of them won't come to mind. At the time everybody knew them, and now the names won't surface.

The second list. Ten things you actually use in your home right now.

That one's easy. You just have to look around.

Put the two lists side by side.

Almost nothing overlaps.

Odd. Why are "what sold" and "what stayed" two different lists?

◆ **The obvious reading — the good ones stay**

Half right.

Some of the good ones stay. But look closely at what stayed and a problem appears.

A fair number of the survivors were judged badly at first. Some didn't sell and looked like they'd soon be gone.

Meanwhile, of the things called the best of their year, only a handful are still here.

So what's needed to stay isn't quality.

What's needed to stay is a route.

Count the routes and you get the table of contents of this book.

◆ **Two questions, four boxes**

Take one object and ask only two questions.

Did it break out at the start? Is it still here?

Two questions, yes or no each, so four boxes.

	Still here	Gone
It broke out	② Broke out and stayed	① Broke out and vanished
It didn't	③ Arrived late	— Never recorded

Three boxes become stories. One doesn't.

◆ **The box with no name has to come first**

The bottom right box has no label.

Things that didn't sell at the start and aren't here now. **By count this box is overwhelmingly larger than the other three combined.**

And nobody records it.

Nothing gets written about an object that failed to sell and disappeared.

So this book has a limit.

This book was written by looking only at what survived and what got noticed.

Far more things may have used the same methods and vanished anyway. There's no way to check.

Stating that limit first has a purpose.

This book is not saying "do this and it will last." **It's saying "the things that lasted had these in common."**

Those are different sentences. The first is a guarantee. The second is an observation.

An observation raises the odds. It doesn't guarantee. **A book that hides that difference ages fast.**

◆ The remaining boxes are Parts Two through Four

Limit stated. Now the map.

① Broke out and vanished. Part Two.

The most common route. And the one with the most to learn. The reasons for dying split three ways, and those three ways are Part Two's three chapters.

② Broke out and stayed. Part Three.

The most important part of this book. ① and ② started from the same place. Where they split is the core.

③ Arrived late. Part Four.

Things that didn't sell and then stayed. Here time appears to have run backwards.

The reading order means something.

First how things die, then how they live, then how they live late. ① and ② have to sit next to each other for the split to be visible.

◆ **There is one more route**

There's a route that doesn't fit a four-box table.

Something that sat quietly for a long time and suddenly broke out.

A steady seller becoming a bestseller.

You could call it a kind of ③. Its nature is different.

In ③ the original maker is usually no longer there. By the time the world came back, the company was gone or the person had died.

On the fourth path the maker is alive. So this is the only route you can actually collect on.

Part Five is that story. Two chapters only, and the center of gravity of this book is in them.

A warning belongs here immediately.

Holding on does not mean breaking out.

Far more things hold on and then quietly disappear with nothing happening. Not admitting that turns Part Five into comfort, and comfort ages a book.

So Chapter 15 opens with "**why most of them can't catch it.**" The hope in front of it is only worth something after the conditions are stated honestly.

◆ **The words this book uses**

That's Part One. All the tools are out. Collected on one page. Everything after this is said in these words.

Three clocks — where you are now.

Clock	Cycle and nature
The fashion clock	Months. Runs on what others are doing
The generation clock	Ten to thirty years. Runs on the years you grew up in
The need clock	Doesn't turn. Hooked to the body and to life events

Four bridges — where you can go.

Bridge	The question
Repeat	When it's used up, do you buy it again?
Shape	Do people recognize it without being told?
Patina	Does time add value?
Handoff	Does it pass to the next person?

Four paths — what happened so far.

Path	The route	Where it's covered
①	Broke out and vanished	Part Two
②	Broke out and stayed	Part Three
③	Arrived late	Part Four
④	Sat, then suddenly broke out	Part Five

Part Six turns these three sets of tools into a maker's checklist.

◆ Three things this book does not promise

Narrowing the promise makes a book last.

One, no guaranteed method for making a bestseller.

Luck matters a great deal. Chapter 17 only covers raising

the odds.

Two, no claim that holding on eventually pays off.

Chapter 15 proves the opposite first.

Three, the survivor problem gets repeated, not buried.

Each part notes where the opposite cases might be.

A book that overstates is old in three years.

**Overstating while claiming to write something
durable doesn't hold together.**

◆ One Line Today

Draw four boxes. Across the top, still here and gone.

Down the side, broke out and didn't.

First, sort ten things you know into the four boxes. If they pile into one box, your range is narrow. Notice which box it is.

Second, put whatever you're making now onto the table.

If it hasn't broken out and it's still here, you're in the bottom left box.

Then one last question.

Which box are you trying to get to? And do you know the route?

Answering "no" is normal. **Knowing that route is what the remaining sixteen chapters do.**

Part Two · First Path · Broke Out and Vanished

◆ Why the dead ones come first

Three chapters. And the first part of this book where names appear.

Starting with the survivors feels better. Ordering it that way leaves less to learn.

Line up only what survived and **too many things look like the reason.** It was a good product. Luck was with it. People loved it. All true, and all useless.

Start with what vanished and it changes.

Those were good products too, and people loved them at the time. **So those aren't the reason they split.**

A trait the dead ones also had cannot be the reason the others lived.

Part Two does the filtering. When Part Three looks at the survivors, the already-filtered traits don't get counted again.

◆ **The autopsy format**

The three chapters here follow the same order.

when it broke out → what was actually
being sold →

when it turned → what got cut first

The last box matters.

When something collapses, several things collapse at once and the cause disappears. **Finding the one thing that got cut first is the autopsy.**

◆ **Why recent examples appear only in this part**

This book has a rule. **The names of recently popular things are used only in Part Two.**

Part One and Part Six contain none. Those places have to last.

Part Two is different. **Here a name going stale helps the argument rather than hurting it.**

If someone opens this book years from now, sees a name in Chapter 5, and asks "what was that?" — the question itself proves the part.

The reader confirms for themselves that what was called vanished did vanish.

◆ **Three ways of dying**

Chapter	What got cut first	The product was
5	The talk — the conversation	Fine

Chapter	What got cut first	The product was
	ended	
6	The slot — the category disappeared	Actually good
7	The scarcity — they gave it away themselves	Still selling well

In all three, nothing was wrong with the product.

So making a better product stops none of them.

Stopping them means looking somewhere else, and where that is, is Part Two's answer.

Chapter 5 — The Talk Was the Lifespan

◆ "Barely used it"

Search for a certain kind of object on a resale app and sometimes a strange screen comes up.

Hundreds of the same thing, listed at once. Even the camera angles are similar.

The descriptions are nearly identical.

Barely used it. Just taking up space, so I'm clearing it out.

The sellers don't know each other. They bought the same object at the same time and are selling it at the same time.

This object was not discarded because it broke.

Not one line complains about quality. Several insist it works perfectly. It works perfectly and nobody uses it.

Odd. Not long ago you couldn't get one. What got cut?

◆ **The obvious reading — fad products vanish because they're badly made**

Cheap to make, sell fast, get out.

Not even half right.

Plenty of fad products are well made. The dessert that made people queue was not bad. The machine everyone bought was not unusable.

And this reading has a larger problem.

If bad quality were the cause, **the answer is simple**. Make it well. If that answer were right, Part Two would be three pages.

The well-made ones vanished too. **So that isn't the reason.**

Three cases, sorted by what got cut first.

◆ **Eaten talk — when the queue was the product**

For a while the same signboard appeared on every street, selling a dessert. Taiwanese-style castella did it, and after that, sugar-coated fruit skewers sold under the Korean name *tanghulu*.¹

The franchise from the opening — five hundred stores in two years — is the second one.

Both were selling the **talk** from the previous chapter.

Something needs care here. What people bought was not only the food.

The queue was part of the product.

Having queued. Being able to photograph having queued.
That was in the package.

Which gives this business an unusual property.

The moment supply increases, half the product disappears.

When you can buy it anywhere the queue is gone, and
when the queue is gone there's no reason to take the
picture.

This kind of food has one more trait in common.

It isn't hard to make.

Buy a machine, or learn it in a few days. There's no way
to block it. Put a trademark on it and a similar name opens
next door.

So supply grows much faster than demand. **And you
learn you've passed the line only after you've passed it.**

◆ **Owned talk — when it's worthless once everyone has one**

For one stretch, a palm-sized electronic device spread widely among children. A toy for keeping a digital pet.²

This one isn't food. It doesn't get eaten. It ended faster.

The reason is in the previous chapter.

An object on the fashion clock is no fun to own alone.

Everyone in the class has to have one for it to be a conversation. When the conversation ends, what's in the hand loses its value too.

The object is unchanged and its value sits in other people's hands.

This produces a strange timetable.

The moment everyone has one is **the peak and the terminus at once**. The best-selling month is the most dangerous month.

◆ Heard talk — when repetition is consumption

There's a song that was everywhere that summer. By the next year you barely hear it.

Here the structure of this chapter shows most clearly.

Listening is using it up.

Clothes don't shrink from being worn; machines remain after being used. Talk decreases when consumed.

To someone hearing the song for the twentieth time, it isn't the same song. The song didn't change. **The remaining newness ran out.**

The same thing was happening in the other two cases. The queue and the toy were also shrinking as they were used.

◆ The autopsy — what got cut first

Put the three in one table.

	What was sold	What got cut first	The product was
The queued dessert	Food + the queue	Supply rose and the queue went	Fine
The palm-sized toy	A toy + the classmates	The classmates moved on	Working
That summer's song	A song + newness	Repetition wore the newness out	Unchanged

Read the middle column downward and the answer to this chapter appears.

Talk decreases when used. And using it is the same act as selling it.

That's the structural problem of a fad product. The more you sell, the less there is to sell.

It's the opposite of the manufacturing rule. Usually selling more lowers unit cost and hardens your position. **Here selling more shortens the remaining lifespan.**

◆ **The real risk is somewhere else**

Everything so far is known. Nobody thinks a fad lasts forever.

The real risk isn't that it ends. It's when it ends.

A fad curve is not symmetrical.

Going up takes months. People find out one at a time.

Coming down doesn't work that way. **It becomes uninteresting all at once.**

Why everyone loses interest simultaneously is simple. The signal to lose interest is also talk. "That's over now" spreads exactly as fast.

So in this business **the last one in loses everything.**

Someone reads that it's selling best, and by the time they've built out and opened the doors a few months later, the market in front of them is dark.

Losses in a fad business don't come from chasing the fad. They come from confirming the fad and then chasing it.

◆ So should you not make fad products?

You should. Chapter 1 said a bestseller gives you things nothing else does.

The problem isn't making them. It's **how they're accounted for.**

Treat a fad product as a fad product and it's fine. Most people treat a fad product **like a need product.**

The difference is in fixed cost.

	Handled as a fad	Handled like a need product (risk)
Space	Short lease pop-up	Long contract
Production	Outsourced	Buy the equipment
People	Added when needed	Hired permanently and trained
Stock	Deliberately short	Comfortably long
Payback	All of it within months	Over several years

The last row is the point.

On a fad product, the payback period has to be shorter than the fad.

Write that calculation down at the start and most of the disasters are avoided. And there's only one reason people

don't. **When it's going well, nobody wants to think about the ending.**

◆ **And one more — where the money goes**

Money made on a fad has two places to go.

One is making the same fad bigger. More stores, more production. Chapter 7 covers the result.

The other is buying a bridge.

Spend it on one of the four named in Chapter 2 — Repeat, Shape, Patina, Handoff. They can only be bought while the talk is alive.

Most of the things in Part Three chose the second.

Spend fad money on fad and it ends. Spend fad money on a position and it stays.

◆ **The short version**

Question	This chapter's answer
What was being sold	The object + the talk
Why did it end	Talk decreases when used, and using is selling
Was the product at fault	No. So making it better stops nothing
When is it most dangerous	The best-selling month
Who loses most	The last one in, who confirmed the fad first
What to do	Payback shorter than the fad. Buy a bridge with the proceeds

◆ Sources for this chapter

1. The spread, peak and decline of Taiwanese-style castella shops and of *tanghulu* shops in South Korea, and the store-count trend. Only what is confirmable in official statistics and contemporaneous reporting.

2. The release period of the digital pet toy, the length of the craze, and the later contraction and re-release attempts. Only what the manufacturer's own material confirms.

◆ One Line Today

Open a resale app. **Search the name of one object in your home.**

See how many are listed. Then read three of the descriptions.

- Mostly "it broke" or "I upgraded" — that object still holds its place
- Mostly "**barely used it**" — that object was talk

Then one last question.

When people resell what you're making now, what will they write?

If "I stopped using it" comes to mind, you haven't found the place yet. **Finding it can be done late. It's cheaper while the talk is still alive.**

Chapter 6 — The Slot Disappeared: The Product Was Fine, the Category Wasn't

◆ The drawer of cables

Every house has one drawer with nothing but cables in it.

Take them out and look. About half of them, you can't tell what machine they went with.

Something is odd here.

Those machines weren't thrown out because they broke.

Most of them went into the drawer working, and then one day got discarded.

Different from the last chapter. Those things got boring because the talk ended.

These never got boring. There was just nowhere left to use them.

◆ **The obvious reading — something better came along**

They lost a competition.

Half right.

Some did lose. Look at what vanished and the story doesn't fit.

There was a small, tough music format called the MiniDisc.¹ It sounded good and it didn't break easily. It kept being improved for years.

Very cheap small laptops sold well for a stretch. They were called netbooks.² They didn't disappear because

something was wrong with them. **At that price there was nothing comparable.**

Dedicated in-car navigation units too. Being purpose-built, the screen was larger and the response quicker.

None of the three lost. **The slot they stood in disappeared.**

And there are three ways a slot disappears. The three differ completely in how predictable they are.

◆ **First way · Absorption — whatever is already in your pocket wins**

Navigation units, music players, flashlights, voice recorders, calculators, cameras.

That whole list got pulled into one place. The phone.

Note what happened.

The absorber didn't win by being better.

The dedicated navigation unit had the bigger screen. The dedicated camera took better pictures. The dedicated recorder captured better sound.

They lost anyway. One reason.

Whatever is already in your pocket wins.

When people choose, they don't only count performance. They also count **how many objects they have to carry.**

When one does the job, carrying a second means that second thing can't be merely "a bit better." **It has to be "can't do without."**

So the places where dedicated devices survive are fixed. Where professionals work. Where lives depend on it. Where conditions are rough.

In those places "a bit better" becomes "can't do without."

This way has one piece of good news.

Absorption is predictable.

Look at what people always carry. What that will swallow next is mostly guessable. What can be swallowed is **whatever can become a component.**

◆ **Second way · Skipping — what was built as a bridge**

The MiniDisc sat somewhere slightly different.

It was better than what came before it. And as an object it was better than what came after.

The problem is where it stood.

Between an era of **carrying music on a physical medium** and an era of **not needing to carry it at all.**

A house built on a bridge.

While people are crossing, it's useful. **Once they've crossed, nobody needs the bridge.**

Objects like this have a signature trait.

They solved the problem of their era extremely well. Solving it well made them refined within that problem, and they went when the problem went.

Being well made ties you in deeper.

The sentence from Chapter 2 comes back.

Grab the method and you go when the method goes.

The MiniDisc was holding not "listening to music" but "a way of carrying music."

And this way is **hard to predict.**

Whether the far bank will appear, and when, is difficult to know in advance. Chapter 19 comes back to this.

◆ Third way · Pushing — what nobody asked for

The third is a very different animal.

Home television you watched wearing glasses, in three dimensions, was pushed hard for several years.³

Manufacturers pushed together, it took the front of the shop floor, broadcasts were prepared.

Then it quietly went away.

A personal vehicle you stood on and rode went a similar way.⁴ The claim that cities would be redesigned around it followed it everywhere.

For this one there's a confirmable number.

Around the time production stopped, that machine accounted for **a little over one percent** of the company's total revenue.⁴

Everyone knew the name and the revenue wasn't there.

Recognition and demand can diverge that far.

These two differ decisively from the first two.

They never had a slot before losing it.

Absorption and skipping are slots that existed and then went. Pushing is **a failed attempt to create a slot.**

And here is the most useful test in this chapter.

Did people ask for this, or did we make it and show it to them?

If it's the second, there is no slot yet.

Making it and showing it isn't wrong. Plenty of things nobody asked for have changed the world.

But then **the cost of creating the slot has to be in the budget.** That cost is usually larger than the cost of making the thing.

The real danger of pushing is elsewhere.

The units sold do not prove demand.

Somebody came in to buy a big screen and the 3D function went out attached to it. The number climbs while few people ever turn the function on.

And the reason the manufacturers gave when they dropped the function was exactly that. **There was no demand.**³

It's the reason stated by the people who had been doing the pushing, at the moment they stopped.

When units sold and units used diverge, that number is not a signal.

And this way is **the easiest of the three to predict.** You can know at the start. That nobody asked for it is a fact available on day one.

◆ **What didn't disappear under the same absorption**

A counter-example has to go here. Without it this chapter becomes a chapter about giving up.

The phone swallowed the watch too. For the purpose of telling the time, a wristwatch has nothing left to do.

Wristwatches did not disappear.

The reason is the core of this whole book.

A wristwatch **stopped being a tool for telling the time**. It became something you wear, and something you hand down.

It stepped off the ground where it competed on function and sat down somewhere else.

That's **changing clocks**, from Chapter 2. And it used two of the four bridges. **Shape** and **Handoff**.

What gets absorbed is a function, not an object.

Only an object that is nothing but its function goes when the function goes.

Invert that sentence and the work appears.

Count what your object has besides its function. If the count is zero, building a better function is not the answer.

All of Part Three is how to do that counting.

◆ **The short version**

Way	What happened	Predictable?	What to do
Absorption	What people always carry ate the function	Easily	Build value outside the function
Skippping	People stopped passing through that stage	Hard	Hold the need, not the method
Pushing	There was never a slot	Easiest of all	Ask first whether

Way	What happened	Predictable?	What to do
			anyone asked

The three share one thing.

The product was fine to the end.

So none of the three can be stopped with quality. **Raising quality is especially dangerous in the face of absorption.** The better it's made, the deeper it's tied to that function.

◆ Sources for this chapter

1. The MiniDisc: release period, history of revisions, and the end of production. Only what the manufacturer's announcements confirm.
2. The formation and disappearance of the small-laptop category called netbooks.
3. Home 3D television: the period of introduction, when manufacturers dropped the function from new product

lines, and the reasons they gave. Several manufacturers dropped it in succession and cited lack of demand. Only what their announcements and contemporaneous reporting confirm.

4. The stand-on personal transporter (Segway PT):
release and end of production, and the share of company revenue that product accounted for around the time production ended. Only what the company's statements and contemporaneous reporting confirm.

◆ One Line Today

Pick one machine you use that **does exactly one job**. A dedicated device of any kind.

Write down two things.

First, is something already in your pocket capable of that job?

Second, if so, why do you keep using this machine?

If the only answer to the second is "**because it does it better,**" that machine is headed for the drawer.

If the answer contains something other than function — it fits your hand, it was handed down, you like the time you spend using it — that machine has already moved.

What does the thing you make have besides its function?

Chapter 7 — It Died by Growing: Scarcity Marketing and Rapid Rollout

◆ Three of the same sign on one street

Three of the same signboard, within a two-minute walk.

All three opened the same year. Two closed the following year.

The remaining one has no customers.

The strange thing isn't the closures.

It's that all three opened at the same time.

The three people who opened them didn't know each other. All three looked at the same figures and reached the same conclusion. **This is what's doing best right now.**

All three were correct. At the time it really was doing best.

And all three went under. **Which means there is a structure in which a correct judgment kills you.**

◆ **The obvious reading — if it sells, add capacity**

There's demand, so there's no reason not to supply it.

Half right.

Some businesses can be scaled and some die from being scaled. From the outside the two look identical.

Same revenue, same queue, same requests to come back.

The numbers on the screen are the same.

What separates them isn't a number.

It comes down to what was actually being sold.

The distinction from Chapter 1 changes the decision here.

◆ **Talk demand is a single nationwide quantity**

The most important sentence in this chapter.

If need was being sold, demand exists separately in each area.

Winter comes to every neighborhood and babies are born in every neighborhood. Selling out in one place doesn't reduce demand in the next. **So adding locations adds revenue.**

If talk was being sold, there is one quantity for the whole country.

"That's what everyone's doing now" happens once, nationally. The number of people who respond to that sentence is the entire market.

Open ten locations and you divide that one quantity by ten. **You divide it, and the cost is ten times.**

Here is the arithmetic of rapid rollout.

	Need demand	Talk demand
Open 10 locations	Demand $\times 10$	Demand unchanged
Revenue per location	Holds	One tenth
Total cost	$\times 10$	$\times 10$
Result	It grows	It grows and dies

The same decision is growth on one side and suicide on the other.

The number from the opening is the last row of that table.

That franchise announced its five hundredth store two years in, and **seven months later there were four hundred and ninety.**²

What's worth noticing isn't that it shrank. **It's that nobody said stop while five hundred were being opened.**

Each of them had no reason to stop. That reason is the third way in this chapter.

◆ **The lease outlasts the fad**

Crueler than the arithmetic is the time.

Confirm the fad, find a site, sign, fit out, open. Several months at best.

During those months the fad is still running.

And as the last chapter showed, the fad curve isn't symmetrical. It comes down all at once.

Nobody knows where on the curve opening day falls.

The contract, however, is already signed.

A fad runs for months and a lease runs for years.

That line is the heart of this chapter.

Failure isn't from being bad at the trade. **It's from tying together two things with different lifespans.**

Put the long thing on top of the short thing, and when the short thing ends the long thing is still there. And money leaves every month for it.

◆ **Second way — selling scarcity, then giving it away**

The second route to dying by growth happens in the product, not the locations.

For a while there was a snack that was hard to find.¹ Finding one meant going to several shops, and having found one was itself worth mentioning.

A question has to be asked here.

Did people buy that flavour, or the fact that it was hard to get?

Both, probably. And that's where the trouble starts.

Being hard to get is **an asset that disappears when you increase supply.**

But when the signal says it's selling, you want to increase supply. Someone not being able to buy looks like a loss.

So production goes up. And the moment it does, half the product is gone.

Put that next to the queued dessert from the last chapter and it's the same structure. A queue and a shortage are both **value that requires somebody to go without.**

Which leads to an uncomfortable conclusion.

A business built on scarcity ends the moment it satisfies everyone.

And whoever runs that business is tempted daily, because the people who couldn't buy keep complaining.

This is the one case where doing exactly what customers ask kills you.

Don't misread it. This isn't advice to keep things short on purpose. **It's advice to know from the start that a business built on scarcity is short-lived,** and to build another position while it runs.

◆ **Third way — when someone else carries the risk**

The place in this chapter that most needs a critical eye.

Rapid rollout usually gets called a misjudgment. The head office read the fad wrong.

That explanation is usually false.

Look at the structure of a franchise and the reason appears.

The head office's customer is not the consumer. **It's the franchisee.** Head office revenue comes from fees and from supplying materials.

Which produces this.

When a store opens, the head office earns immediately.

When that store closes two years later, the head office returns nothing.

The party carrying the risk and the party earning the money are different.

So there is no brake. Even if the fad is visibly cooling, head office has no reason to slow openings. **Opening as many as possible before it cools is rational for head office.**

Rapid rollout is not a misjudgment. It's a placement problem. This always happens when the person deciding isn't the person carrying the risk.

That sentence isn't only about franchising.

A business run on other people's money. A role where the reward comes first and the outcome later. An organisation

where whoever decided has moved on by the time the result lands. **Same structure, same result.**

Invert it and you get a test for anyone about to start something.

"Does the person recommending this business lose anything if I fail?"

If the answer is no, what they're saying is not information. It's sales.

◆ **So what should you do when it's going well?**

After three ways it feels airless. Add capacity and you die; don't and you miss the moment.

Here this book's prescription appears for the first time.

When it's going well, add bridges, not locations.

There are things you can only do while the talk is alive.

Bridge	What the talk lets you do
Repeat	Build in a reason to buy again when it's used up
Shape	Fix the form and the colour. Right now people are looking
Patina	Put in the property of improving with use
Handoff	Make it easy to give, easy to hand down

All four are **far more expensive once the talk is over.**

Fix a shape when nobody's looking and nobody learns it.

The real value of a fad isn't the revenue. It's that for a while, people are looking.

What to show them during that window is Part Three.

◆ **Three questions before adding capacity**

Reduced to three so they can be used in the room where it's decided.

One. Where are the buyers coming from?

From the neighborhood, and it may be need demand.

From far away, and it's talk demand. People travel because they heard something.

Two. Is anyone here for the second time?

Lots of first-timers and few returners means talk. This number is easy to count and costs nothing to count.

Three. Is the contract shorter than the expected lifespan?

You have to write down the expected lifespan even though you don't want to. **If you don't, the default becomes "indefinitely," and that default is what ruins people.**

◆ The short version

Way of dying by growth	What was increased	What disappeared
Rapid rollout	Locations	Demand per location. There was only one nationally
Giving up scarcity	Production	The people going without. That was half the product
Separated risk	Franchisees	The brake. The decider carried no risk

All three differ from the last two chapters in one way.

In Chapters 5 and 6 something arrived from outside. The talk ended; the slot vanished.

In Chapter 7 nobody arrived. It was done from inside.

All three of these were decisions made while things were going well. Which makes them the easiest to

prevent, and the least prevented.

◆ Sources for this chapter

1. The snack with a prolonged shortage: release date, the length of the supply shortage, when capacity was expanded, and the sales trend after. Only what the manufacturer's announcements and official statistics confirm.
2. The five-hundredth-store announcement and the store count seven months later for the dessert franchise. To be confirmed against company announcements and franchise disclosure filings. Same item as in the opening's sources.

The revenue structure of franchising is described only as the general structure visible in public disclosure filings. No specific company's fees or supply prices are used until confirmed.

◆ One Line Today

Think of something that's going well right now. It doesn't have to be yours. Something you're watching from the side is fine.

Write three lines.

First, where do the buyers come from? Nearby or far away?

Second, what share of them are here for the second time?

Third, when do you think this ends? **Write a date.**

The third is hard, and because it's hard most people skip it.

Being wrong is fine. Writing it does something on its own.

Once the ending date is written down, what has to be done before then becomes visible alongside it.

And that "what" is Part Three of this book.

Part Three · Second Path · Broke Out and Stayed

◆ These were fads too

Three chapters. And the most important part of this book.

One thing has to be clear first.

**The things in Part Three started from the same place
as the things in Part Two.**

They were enormous topics of conversation. People talked, people queued, not having one felt like being behind.

They were indistinguishable from what's in Part Two.

At the time nobody knew which ones would stay.

So Part Three has one question.

They started from the same place. Where did they split?

◆ One rule — what Part Two also had doesn't count

Look closely at survivors and a problem appears. **Too many things look like the reason.**

Good product. People loved it. Luck held. The maker meant it. All true and all useless.

Everything in Part Two was all of those things.

So this part has a rule.

A trait that Part Two also had is not counted as a reason.

Keep that rule and what remains shrinks hard. And what's left is the real answer.

◆ **The four bridges get used here**

The four named in Chapter 2 come out now.

Chapter	Bridge	The question
8	Patina · Handoff	Does time add value? Does it pass to the next person?
9	Shape	Do people recognize it without being told?
10	Repeat	When the time comes, do you buy it again?

Two are grouped into Chapter 8 for a reason.

Patina and handoff are **the landing bridges**. They decide where an object comes down to when it steps off a fad.

Shape and repeat are **the holding bridges**. They keep it in the place it landed.

Hence the order: 8, then 9, then 10.

◆ And a limit

Part Three looks only at survivors.

Things may have laid the same bridges and vanished anyway. **They probably did. There's just no record.**

As Chapter 4 said, this book is an observation, not a guarantee.

Not "lay a bridge and it will stay," but "**the ones that stayed had bridges laid.**"

Read it with that difference in mind.

Chapter 8 — It Changed Clocks: Coming In on Fashion, Landing on Need

◆ The basketball shoe nobody wears on a basketball court

Watch a game and the shoes change every year. Light, holding the ankle, absorbing impact.

Nobody on that court is wearing a shoe from twenty years ago.

Step outside the arena and it's a different story.

On the street, plenty of people wear shoes whose design is twenty or thirty years old.¹ Built for the game, and pushed out of the game long ago.

The same shoe was retired from one place and kept in another.

Odd. How does something that lost on performance live longer?

◆ The obvious reading — what lasted was a good product from the start

Half right.

Go and read the original descriptions of things that lasted and something strange happens.

The reason you use it now isn't written there.

Built for the game, worn on the street. Built for a worksite, worn on a stage. Built as a children's toy, and now adults buy more of them.

The use the maker wrote down and the use it has now are different.

So it's more accurate to say this.

What lasted wasn't a good object. It was an object that moved.

◆ **The maker doesn't change lanes**

The most important passage in this chapter.

Moving is not decided in a meeting room.

The user does it first.

It wasn't the company that started wearing the game shoe on the street. It wasn't the factory that started wearing the work boot on the stage.

Somewhere, someone used it outside its purpose, it spread, **and the maker found out afterwards.**

That order almost never reverses.

The maker tries to hold the original purpose. They built the plant for it, they've sold on it, they're the expert in it.

So the maker's actual job sounds strange.

Not making it change lanes. Not blocking it from changing lanes.

There are several ways to block, and all of them sound well-intentioned.

"That isn't what it's for." "Using it that way voids the warranty." "It doesn't fit the brand."

All three are correct inside the company. **And all three close the door on moving.**

◆ **Three signals that it's moving**

To not block it you have to notice. There are three signals.

One. You hear about it being used somewhere it wasn't meant for.

It often arrives as a complaint. When "can it also do this?" keeps repeating, it has already started.

Two. The kind of person buying changes.

Ages change, regions change, occupations change. When revenue holds steady but the buyers have shifted, the slot is moving.

Three. People ask you to repair it.

This is the strongest signal.

Nobody repairs an object they can replace. They just buy another. **Asking for a repair means the object has become irreplaceable.**

Repair requests usually get filed as cost. **They are not a cost. They are a measurement.**

If repair requests are rising, that object is changing lanes right now.

◆ **First bridge · Patina — when time adds value**

The first of the two landing bridges.

Time takes value off most objects. New is the most expensive; it gets cheaper with use.

Some objects run the other way.

Leather, heavy cotton, cast iron, wood, instruments.

Things where the marks of use are **value**, not damage.

There are conditions. Not everything takes a patina.

One, it has to change without breaking.

The colour fades and the shape settles while the function holds. Plastic can't do this. It's fine and then it cracks.

Two, the changed form has to be yours.

Yours and someone else's have to age differently. If they age the same way, it's just worn out.

Three, the beginning has to be slightly uncomfortable.

Here comes the uncomfortable part.

Things that take a patina are usually stiff at the start.

Leather is hard; cast iron is heavy and needs attention.

A patina is a device that converts early discomfort into later attachment.

Which runs directly against where the market is going.

Most improvements are aimed at making the beginning easier.

Putting a patina in requires the nerve to make the beginning less comfortable.

And that decision reduces early sales. **So most don't do it.** That's why Part Three is short.

◆ Second bridge · Handoff — when it passes to the next person

The second landing bridge.

Among building-block toys there is an old one.² What matters isn't the toy. It's **the coupling**.

That coupling was patented more than sixty years ago.²

Blocks made then fit blocks made now.²

To hold that one fact, the company gave something up.

For sixty years it did not move to a better coupling.

That single fact does a great deal of work.

A parent can bring out their own childhood box and give it to a child. And buy a new box and mix them.

Handing it down doesn't stop anyone from buying new.

Three things are required for a handoff.

One, it doesn't break. Obvious, and therefore often forgotten.

Two, the old and the new get used together.

This is decisive. Break compatibility and what was handed down becomes a memento with no use. **An object with no use gets thrown out no matter who gave it to you.**

Three, there has to be a reason to hand it over.

This is the hardest.

What gets handed down isn't the object. **It's the time spent with the object.**

So the object needs somewhere for memory to attach. Somewhere to write a name, somewhere to put a date, somewhere the traces of shared use can stay.

An object memory can't attach to doesn't get handed down however sturdy it is. **It sits in storage and then it's**

discarded.

◆ The ones that moved, in one table

Three cases, marked with the bridges they used.

	From → To	Bridges used	Who moved it first
Game shoe	Arena → street	Shape · Patina	The user
Building blocks	Toy → standard	Handoff · Shape	Former users who became parents
A talked- about novel	Front table → classroom	Repeat · Handoff	Teachers and parents

Read the right-hand column down and the chapter's
answer returns.

In none of the three did the maker do the moving.

◆ But changing lanes reduces revenue

Look at this critically. If changing lanes is so good, why doesn't everyone do it?

Because it loses money. Immediately.

One, the price can fall. What you charged for professional use may not hold for everyday use.

Two, handing down means not buying new. The better the handoff works, the lower the new sales.

Three, keeping compatibility means not changing. To keep fitting the old parts you give up a better design.

Four, patina lengthens the replacement cycle. Things used for a long time sell less often.

All four are true. So refusing to change lanes always has a plausible basis.

Judged by the quarter, refusing is always right.

The value of changing lanes isn't calculated in current revenue. It's calculated by whether you exist in ten years.

And ten years from now doesn't appear in this quarter's report. The split between Part Two and Part Three is exactly in that calculation.

◆ The short version

Question	This chapter's answer
Who moves it	The user. The maker finds out afterwards
The maker's job	Not making it move — not blocking it
How do you notice	Off-label questions · buyers change · repair requests

Question	This chapter's answer
Patina requires	Changes without breaking · ages differently for each · starts uncomfortable
Handoff requires	Doesn't break · old and new used together · memory attaches
Why doesn't everyone	All four reduce current revenue

◆ Sources for this chapter

1. The release period and original purpose of a running or basketball shoe still produced on an old design, and when it moved to everyday wear. Only what the manufacturer's material and contemporaneous records confirm.
2. When the coupling system of the building-block toy (LEGO) was patented, and whether product made then is compatible with current product. Only what patent

records and the manufacturer's announcements confirm.

◆ One Line Today

Pick one object in your home you've used **for a long time**. Five years or more will do.

Check two things.

First, was it better new, or is it better now?

If you answered **now**, that object has a patina. Write one line on what did it. The material, the shape, or what you did with it.

Second, could you hand this to someone?

If yes, write why it's worth handing on. If no, write what's missing. Is it broken, does it not fit, or does no memory attach?

Then one last question.

Is the thing you make better after five years than it is new?

Answering no is normal. Most objects are like that. **It only means that object can be sold as new, and in the contest of newness a newer thing always arrives.**

Chapter 9 — Shape Replaced the Name: Recognized Without Being Told

◆ Take every label off and lay them out

Put ten objects on a table. Then peel off every label.

Most of them become unidentifiable. You can't tell whose it is, or whether it was expensive.

A few you still recognize.

The curve of a bottle, the tread pattern on a sole, one colour on a wrapper, the angle of a handle.

The name came off and the name is still there.

Odd. The name was erased. Why is it still there?

◆ **The obvious reading — a brand is a logo**

Make a good logo, spread it widely, and you have a brand.

Half right.

What's missing is the order in which a person recognizes an object.

A logo has to be read. A shape is known before reading.

Recognizing letters requires stopping the eye and focusing. Shape is processed before that. From a distance, small, blurred — still known.

The consequences are large.

	Logo	Shape
To recognize it	Takes reading time	Known before reading
If you can't read	Not recognized	Recognized

	Logo	Shape
In another country	Needs translating	Works as is
Far away · small	Invisible	Visible
On a shelf	You have to pick it up	You know it walking past

The last row is what this chapter is worth.

Shape works while you're spending nothing on advertising.

Sitting on the shelf is itself the advertisement. And that advertisement has no monthly cost.

The property from Chapter 1 — that a steady seller's cost barely grows with revenue — has shape as one of its actual mechanisms.

◆ **Three conditions for a shape becoming a name**

Not every form becomes a name. Three things are needed.

One. It has to be drawable.

This is a test you can actually run.

Hand people paper and ask them to draw it from memory.

If it comes out roughly right there's a shape. If it doesn't, there isn't.

Drawable shapes have something in common. They're simple. Describing one takes no more than a sentence.

Two. It has to not change.

Shape is built by accumulation. The same form has to be seen for a long time before it becomes a name.

Change it every year and nothing accumulates. And the urge to change comes from inside. **The maker sees their own object far more often than anyone else.**

Seeing it often makes you tired of it. Being tired makes you want to change it. The buyer sees it a few times a

year. The maker sees it daily.

The one who got bored is the maker, not the buyer.

There's a piece of evidence the law has attached to this.

Sometimes the shape itself is registered as a trademark.¹

Not the logo, not the name — **the shape of the bottle** is the mark. Make a bottle of that shape and you have used the trademark by doing so.

A position given only to words and pictures went to a form.

Three. It has to come from function.

The most important and the most often missed.

The shapes that lasted mostly became that shape for a reason.

A tread pattern exists so it doesn't slip. A curve in a bottle exists so a wet hand can hold it. The angle of a handle exists so less force is needed.

A shape that came from function has a large advantage.

It needs no explanation. Look at it and you know why. And **it doesn't age.** As long as the function holds, the shape doesn't get strange.

A shape made as decoration ages with its era.

So there's a test.

Did this shape come from function, or from the taste of its time?

Fix a shape that came from taste, and when that taste passes, you pass with it. **The shape stops being an asset and starts looking dated.**

◆ **Shape isn't only form**

The scope has to widen here. What matters about shape isn't form. It's that **it doesn't go through language.**

Five other things do the same job.

Sound. The sound of opening, of closing, the short note at startup.

A single colour. Recognizing something by one colour. Colour is processed even faster than form.

Proportion. The ratio of width to height. The form can change; the ratio stays.

Texture. How it feels in the hand. This one doesn't need the eye at all.

Smell. The longest-lasting in memory and the least used.

All five are recognized without reading. And all five **can't be peeled off the way a logo can.**

A logo can be removed, covered, forged. A sound and a texture can't.

To copy them you have to change the object itself. And then it isn't a cheap imitation any more.

◆ **What you lose by having a shape**

The passage in this chapter that has to be honest.

Shape is an asset and a shackle.

Fix a form and the form starts blocking things.

You could make it lighter but the silhouette would change, so you don't. You could make it cheaper but that texture wouldn't survive, so you don't. You found a better structure but it wouldn't be recognizable, so you don't.

That list gets longer with time.

So a company with a shape is **late to technical change**. Late not from incompetence but from defending an asset.

There's no way to have a shape without paying this.

And there's one especially dangerous case.

When the form was on the fashion clock to begin with.

Fix a form made from the taste of its era and the object passes when the taste passes. Except you've already fixed it, so you can't change it.

The shape ties the object to its own decade.

◆ **So how do you change it — erasure**

The time comes when you have to change while holding a shape. There's a method, and it's the one actually used.

Keep the skeleton and change the flesh.

First you have to know **what the skeleton is**. Most people don't know which element of their object people actually recognize. They guess.

The way to find out is simple. **Erase one thing at a time.**

Show a version with the colour removed. Still recognized?
Keep the form, remove the pattern. Still recognized? Keep
only the proportion, remove the rest. Still recognized?

**The one thing still recognized after everything is
erased is the skeleton.**

Hold that one and everything else can change.

The law has attached evidence here too.

The company behind that bottle once tried to register **a
new bottle shape with the grooves removed** as a shape
trademark. **It was refused.**¹

The reason is this chapter, exactly. **That shape hadn't
accumulated yet.**

Same company, same name, same drink — the form
changed and the shape asset didn't come with it.

**A shape doesn't belong to the company. It belongs
to that form.**

Which is why changing means finding the skeleton by erasure first.

This work costs almost nothing. Paper and ten people. **Not many companies have done it.**

Most do the opposite. They change everything a little without knowing what the skeleton is.

The recognizable element slowly disappears, and **one day nobody recognizes it and nobody can explain why.**

◆ **The short version**

Question	This chapter's answer
Why is shape strong	It doesn't go through language. Known before reading
What does it save	Advertising. Sitting on the shelf is the advertisement
Three conditions	Drawable · doesn't change · came from function

Question	This chapter's answer
Is shape only form	Sound · colour · proportion · texture · smell do the same job
What do you lose	You can't change. You're late to technical change
Most dangerous case	When the form came from the taste of its time
How do you change it	Erasure finds the skeleton. Hold only that one

**Shape isn't an asset you get for free. It's an asset
bought by selling your freedom to change.**

◆ Sources for this chapter

1. A case where the shape of a bottle is itself registered as a trademark (the Coca-Cola contour bottle), and the case of the same company's attempt to register a new bottle shape with the grooves removed, which was

refused. To be confirmed against national trademark registries and the decisions.

The registration date is not given in the text. Different sources give different years, and first registration appears to be mixed up with renewals and additional filings. No year goes in until the registry itself settles which is correct.

◆ One Line Today

Get paper and a pencil. Then don't look at the objects.

From memory, draw three things you like. They don't have to be good drawings. Recognizable is enough.

Then compare them with the real objects.

- If one came out roughly right, that object **has a shape**
- If nothing surfaces when you try, you know that object only by its logo

And one more.

If you asked people to draw what you make, from memory, what would come out?

If the answer is nothing, that's the work in front of you.

Making a shape doesn't cost much. Not changing it once it's made is the hard part.

Chapter 10 — The Calendar Sells It for You: Demand That Comes Back Every Year

◆ Forgotten for eleven months, then it returns

Every December the same songs come back. In shops, on the street, on the radio.

They aren't new songs. They came out a long time ago.¹

Something strange here.

Songs usually get heard less as time passes. New ones arrive, people move on, and they quietly go.

These songs get heard more as time passes.

And the stranger part is what happens in the other eleven months.

Nobody listens to them for most of the year. They are completely forgotten.

Forgotten, and not dead.

◆ **The obvious reading — seasonal goods are at a disadvantage**

Half right.

The selling window is short. True. There's something bought with that.

The calendar does the advertising.

An ordinary product has to keep spending so people don't forget it. Stop, and you're forgotten; forgotten, and it's over.

A seasonal product doesn't need that. **When the time comes, people remember on their own.**

December arrives and carols come to mind; the cold arrives and heavy clothes do. Nobody has to tell them.

This is the same class of asset as shape in the last chapter.

An asset maintained without a monthly payment.

◆ Repeat has three sources

Repeat is the first bridge, named in Chapter 2. It gets opened up here.

There are only three ways to make someone buy again.

One. Consumption — it runs out, so you buy more.

Food, detergent, fuel, supplies. The most common and the most reliable.

Two. Cycle — the time comes, so you buy again.

Seasons, holidays, the start of school, birthdays, scheduled maintenance.

Three. Stage — once at each stage of a life.

The doors from Chapter 3 belong here.

The second is the strongest of the three, for one reason.

Nothing has to be remembered.

Consumption requires noticing that you've run out. Not noticing means not buying. So you need a device that says it's empty.

A stage can't be scheduled. It depends on that person's circumstances.

A cycle is announced by the calendar. Both the buyer and the seller know in advance.

◆ Four things seasonal demand gives you

Four advantages, put together.

One, the time to promote is fixed. You don't have to spend all year. A few weeks will do.

Two, being forgotten is survivable.

This one is decisive.

For an ordinary product, being forgotten is the end. **A seasonal product can afford it.** Being forgotten is partly what makes December feel welcome.

Three, you can plan. You roughly know when and how much will sell. Stock and staffing can be set in advance.

Four, new people arrive every year. The renewing structure from Chapter 3 attaches by itself. Every year there are people going through it for the first time.

Put the four together and nearly all the conditions of a steady seller are met. **Which is why so many of the things that lasted are seasonal.**

◆ **But there are three costs**

Seasonal demand is not free.

One. Miss a year and you wait a year.

If preparation was late, or stock ran short, or there was a quality incident, that year is gone entirely.

An ordinary product can make it back next month. **A seasonal product has no next month.**

So in this business **a mistake costs twelve times as much.**

Two. No cash comes in for eleven months.

This is what actually kills companies.

The classic case of a successful product inside a failing company is here. Materials have to be bought early, people have to stay, rent leaves every month.

Without the cash to sit through the season, don't run a seasonal product.

That's a financing problem, not a product problem. And the financing structure is rarely examined when the product is chosen.

Three. The season can move.

The least visible risk.

A season looks like it's on the need clock. Winter arrives every year. **But what people do in that season sits on a different clock.**

What gets exchanged at a holiday, what gets prepared for the start of school, where people go in winter.

These are on the generation clock. They change over ten or twenty years.

The season is fixed. What people do in that season is not.

So what a seasonal business checks each year is not the weather. **It's whether what people do on that day is still the same.**

◆ Can you make a season?

Some seasons were made. Among customs of exchanging things on particular dates, some do not have deep roots.²

Three conditions.

One, there has to be a date. The date is the memory device. No date, no custom.

Two, there has to be someone to exchange with. A thing you do alone rarely becomes a custom. **There has to be a handing-over motion for it to spread to the next person.**

Three, a first-timer has to know exactly what to do. Complicated rules don't spread.

But something has to be said plainly here.

Whoever makes a season does not own it.

The moment it becomes a custom, everyone sells on that day. The company that made it sells, the followers sell, the corner shop sells.

Making a season means making a market, not taking one.

So anyone trying to make a season has to take one more thing with it. **The default position** from Chapter 3.

The place that comes to mind when people ask "what do I get?" on that day. **The season gets shared. The default is one.**

◆ Attaching a cycle to something with no season

Most objects have no season. Four things can still be done, in order of cheapness.

One. Attach to a date that already exists.

Far cheaper than making a season. Find a day when people already do something and make a place there.

Two. Design the consumption rate.

Decide how long it takes to use up, and build to that. Too long and you're forgotten; too fast and it's a burden.

Three. Let the object announce its own replacement time.

A colour changes, a mark appears, the wear becomes visible. **The point is not leaving it to human memory.**

Four. Make something that runs in yearly units.

Something with the year on it, something only made that year, something filled in over time. **Anything collected acquires a cycle on its own.**

All four cost design rather than money. And all four only work **if you don't change them after building them.**

◆ The short version

Question	This chapter's answer
The advantage	The calendar does the advertising
Why is cycle strongest	Unlike consumption, nothing has to be remembered
Being forgotten	A seasonal product comes back anyway
First cost	Miss a year, wait a year. A mistake costs twelve times
Second cost	Eleven months of cash. The product succeeds and the company fails
Third cost	The season is fixed; what people do on that day is not
Making a season	You made a market, not taken one

◆ Sources for this chapter

1. The release dates of the songs that return to distribution and broadcast every December, and the pattern of their annual re-entry. Only what national official charts confirm.
2. Customs of exchanging goods on a particular date that formed in the twentieth century or later, and how they formed. Only cases with confirmable primary sources.

◆ One Line Today

Open a calendar. Paper is better, a screen is fine.

Mark every day in the year on which you always buy something.

Holidays, birthdays, the start of a school year, the turn of a season, scheduled maintenance, anniversaries. More of them appear than you'd expect.

When they're marked, look at two things.

First, write down what you buy on each day. If you buy the same thing every year, that is your steady seller.

Second, are there months with no marks?

An empty month is a seat nobody has taken yet.

Then one last question.

Which day on the calendar is the thing you make attached to?

If it's attached to no day, it means you have to pay, every single time, **to manufacture the reason for anyone to think of it.**

Part Four · Third Path · Arrived Late

◆ Where time appears to run backwards

Three chapters. And the most consoling part of this book.

Which is why it has to be the most accurate.

The things here didn't sell at first. They looked like they'd soon be gone, and for a while they effectively were.

And they're here now.

◆ The format changes

Parts Two and Three were autopsies. One object, opened up.

Part Four is a **chronicle**. It follows the time.

made → didn't sell → what happened
meanwhile →
where the direction turned → now

The middle box is the work of this part.

What kept it alive during the years it wasn't selling.

◆ **It splits three ways**

Three ways of arriving late, sorted by what changed.

Chapter	What changed	The object was
11	The world changed and a slot appeared	Unchanged
12	The use changed and it moved	Unchanged
13	Nothing changed.	Unchanged

People kept it

The right-hand column is the same in all three.

The object didn't change from beginning to end. So what's to be learned here isn't how to fix an object.

◆ Two risks in this part

One. The survivor problem is worst here.

The unnamed box from Chapter 4 has to come out again. The things that simply vanished without selling are overwhelmingly more numerous.

What's here is known to us **because it survived. There's no list of the ones that died under the same conditions.**

So the lesson of this part is **not "hold on and it'll come."**

The question is a different one.

What bought it the time?

Two. This territory has more stories than facts.

Dramatic anecdotes attach themselves to things discovered late. And those anecdotes usually have no source.

This book's rule is applied most strictly here.

Widely known does not mean true.

Unverified anecdotes were **cut whole** rather than softened. How many were cut is recorded in *How This Book Was Made*.

Chapter 11 — The Market Came Late: Made Too Early

◆ A book that didn't change a word, and started circulating

There are books in a library's stacks that almost never go out. Borrowed once every few years.

Then for some of them, one year, the loans start climbing. A few years later it's always out.

Something needs checking.

Not one word of that book changed.

No revised edition, no rewrite. The same sentences on the same paper.

Everything that changed was outside.

Odd. **If an object didn't change and its value did, the value was never inside the object.**

◆ **The obvious reading — it was ahead of its time**

The most common explanation for not selling.

Half right. And it's the dangerous half.

"Ahead of its time" sounds like praise. So hearing it is reassuring.

But there's no diagnosis in it.

It wasn't ahead. **It was standing in a slot that didn't exist yet.** And a slot that doesn't exist doesn't appear by itself.

Follow the late arrivals in time order and they share one thing.

The world didn't come on its own. Something

brought it.

This chapter calls that something a **carrier**. There are three.

◆ **First carrier · The price fell**

Some things have the idea first and the materials later.

The design was finished long ago and what it needed was too expensive. Electricity was expensive, or communication, or computation, or moving things.

The day that price drops below some line, the thing suddenly becomes possible.

An important property here.

The price falls gradually. The becoming-possible arrives all at once.

Below the line nothing works; across the line everything does. So from outside it looks like it appeared out of

nowhere.

This is **the only carrier you can predict**. Because you can write down in advance which price has to fall.

◆ **Second carrier • It moved to a different place**

A film that failed in cinemas sometimes becomes a classic later.¹

One prison film did this. In cinemas it didn't earn back what it cost to make. It won no awards.¹

Then the distributor pressed a large run of rental tapes the following year and pushed them out.¹ It went to number one on the rental charts that year.¹

A few years later a cable channel took the broadcast rights and ran it repeatedly.¹ It became a fixture of that channel's schedule.

The film didn't change. It's the same print. What changed is **where it's watched**.

A cinema is a hard place. A fixed time, money paid in advance, two hours of being held there. So the audience picks the safe thing.

Watching at home is different. It costs far less, you can stop halfway, you can follow a recommendation.

The same object, and the hurdle differs by place.

That film lost in cinemas not because it was bad. **The other films opening the same week looked safer.**

In a cinema the safe thing wins. In a living room that criterion disappears.

This structure isn't only in film.

Some things live only in expensive places before coming down to cheap ones. Specialist shops before general shops. Big cities before small ones.

Each step down multiplies the number of people who might try it.

Failing in the first place does not mean failing in the next.

◆ Third carrier · The people changed

A novel that didn't sell in its own time sometimes ends up in classrooms a generation later.²

This carrier is far slower than the other two. Ten years, twenty. And when it works, not only is the object unchanged — **the world's prices are unchanged too.**

What changed is the reader.

The same sentences sounded strange in that era and obvious in the next. The generation clock from Chapter 2 runs backwards here.

Something on the generation clock goes down when the generation goes. **But something that was out of step with its generation comes into step when the generation passes.**

The same clock is a loss for one object and a gain for another. Which one depends on **whether the thing agrees with the majority now or disagrees with it.**

◆ **Ahead, or wrong?**

The most useful passage in this chapter.

Someone who isn't selling right now doesn't know which one they are.

Ahead doesn't sell, and wrong doesn't sell. From the outside they're identical.

And most people believe they're ahead. It's far easier to bear.

There's one way to tell.

Are there many people saying it's good, or are there people actually using it?

These are completely different signals.

Something ahead is used by a few. The number is small, and those people keep using it. They're inconvenienced without it.

Something wrong is praised by many. "Nice." "That would be useful." "Hope it goes well." And nobody uses it.

Praise is free and use costs something. **Only the thing that costs something is a signal.**

So while it isn't selling, the number to count isn't revenue.

How many people keep using it. If that number is small but not falling, the slot is missing — not the thing.

◆ **If you arrived early, what do you do?**

Say you've confirmed you're ahead. Four things.

One. Surviving is the strategy.

Chapter 7's arithmetic applies again. There, the payback had to be shorter than the fad. Here it has to be longer.

Because you don't know how long the wait is, make the monthly outflow minimal. That means enduring a state with no glamour, no growth and nothing to announce.

Two. Keep selling, even a little.

Stop and you're gone. Gone, and there's nobody to receive the world when it comes. Among the things in Part Four, the maker was rarely still there.

Three. Leave a record.

Things discovered late have something in common. **The original still existed.**

The print was in storage, the book was on a shelf, someone kept a box. If it hadn't survived there'd be nothing to rediscover.

Keeping what you made findable costs almost nothing.

And not doing it makes the later part impossible.

Four. Don't wait for the carrier — write it down.

The thing you can do today.

On paper, three lines.

What has to get cheaper for this to work? Which place, one step down, would multiply the people who'd try it by ten? Which people, once grown, would find this obvious?

Write the three and you'll recognize the signal when it arrives. Don't write them and the signal passes unseen.

Waiting and watching are not the same thing.

◆ **But most of them weren't there**

To close this chapter honestly.

For a large share of the late arrivals, **the maker was not there.**

The company was gone, the person had died, or they were doing something else. When the world came, somebody else collected.

So this isn't a chapter about waiting.

It's a chapter about building a state in which you can wait.

How that state gets built, and what happens to the ones who were still alive, is Part Five.

◆ **The short version**

Carrier	What changes	How long	Predictable?
The price fell	Materials · power · communication ·	A few years	Yes

Carrier	What changes	How long	Predictable?
	computation		
It moved place	Where it's sold, where it's seen	A few years	Partly
The people changed	The generation reading or watching	Ten years or more	Hard

Something ahead is used by a few. Something wrong is praised by many.

◆ Sources for this chapter

1. A prison film with weak theatrical results that later became widely known through home media and broadcast (*The Shawshank Redemption*): its production budget and theatrical gross, the quantity of rental tapes distributed the following year and its

rental ranking, and when a cable channel took the broadcast rights. Only what distributor records and contemporaneous reporting confirm.

2. A novel whose sales were poor on publication and which later entered school curricula: its sales during the author's life and when it entered curricula. Only what publisher material and curriculum records confirm.

◆ One Line Today

Pick one thing you're doing that **isn't going well**.

Count two things.

First, how many people have told you it's good?

Second, how many people **actually used it** last month?

If the second is zero, the problem may not be a missing slot. If the second is small but not zero and not falling, the slot is missing.

Then write three lines.

What has to get cheaper for this to work? Which place, one step down, would multiply the people who'd try it by ten? Which people, once grown, would find this obvious?

If all three are blank, there's no reason to wait. **If even one fills in, that line is what you're watching.**

Chapter 12 — The Use Changed: Surviving Somewhere It Wasn't For

◆ The adhesive that doesn't stick well

Someone trying to make a strong adhesive produced one that doesn't stick well.¹

It holds, but weakly. Pull and it comes off. As an adhesive, a failure.

The person who made it didn't throw it away. With no use for it, he **spent years walking it around the company, showing it.**¹

Much later another researcher saw it and thought of something. Paper bookmarks kept falling out of his hymnal in the church choir.¹

That substance became something in every office. A note you stick on and peel off.

Twelve years passed between the discovery and the product.¹

Something needs checking.

The substance was not fixed.

It wasn't made to stick better. It was used exactly as it was.

Odd. The cause of the failure became the core of the product unchanged.

◆ The obvious reading — it was luck

Read as a story about good fortune.

Half right.

It was made by accident. True. But accidents happen everywhere.

Getting something other than what you expected is common in a laboratory. Most of it is discarded that day.

So the question isn't whether the accident happened.

Was there anywhere for the accident to land?

If that failure had come out somewhere else, it would have left one line in a record and ended.

Look again at what actually happened in that case.

The person who made it spent years carrying it around and showing it to people.

What this book sets down later as a prescription, he was already doing. And the one who found the use was not the maker. **It was somebody else who saw it.**

Look at the things that survived by changing use and there are three routes.

◆ **First route · Where the flaw is the requirement**

The adhesive belongs here.

Weak adhesion is a flaw in the adhesive market. In a place where things have to be stuck and unstuck, it's the specification.

The order of thinking can be inverted here.

Usually it goes: **find the flaw** → **fix it**.

There's another order: **find the flaw** → **find the place that needs that property**.

Using the second order changes the definition of a flaw.

A flaw is not a property. It's a mismatch between a property and a place.

A property in itself is neither good nor bad. Heavy, slow, doesn't stick, takes a long time, small, not attractive.

Almost nothing on that list is useless everywhere.

There are places that need heavy and places that need slow. **Drying slowly is a flaw in one market and a requirement in another.**

And this is work you can do immediately.

Write down five flaws in your product. Beside each, write one more line.

Where is this property actually required?

Leave it blank if it's blank. It might take years to fill. **But if it isn't written down there's no chance of it filling at all.**

◆ Second route · From the rough place to the comfortable one

A boot made for a worksite is on a stage.²

That boot, built on an air-cushioned sole, was first worn by **postal workers and factory workers.**² It was a cheap work boot.

Some years later one group of young people started wearing them. Then the next group, and the group after that.²

The maker never tried to sell to any of them.

A food made for army supply became home cooking.³

The direction here is consistent. **Always from rough to comfortable.**

The reverse is rare. Something made for daily use rarely becomes the worksite standard later.

The reason is structural.

A rough environment demands more than everyday life does.

It can get wet, it can be dropped, it has to last years, it has to be repairable. Meeting that makes it overbuilt.

And when that object comes down into daily life, the overbuilding comes with it.

Excess quality becomes two things in daily life.

One is **patina**, from Part Three. Used for years, it takes one. The other is **shape**. A form demanded by a rough place is a form from function.

The condition from Chapter 9 is already met. **A shape that came from function doesn't age.**

One more thing attaches.

The origin is the story.

"What miners wore." "What soldiers carried." "What rescue crews used." That line cannot be manufactured by advertising. It has to have been true.

There's a condition. Not everything from a rough place makes it.

It has to be visible in daily life.

Boots, outerwear and bags are visible, so the story attaches. A component inside a machine, however remarkable, gets no story.

◆ **Third route · An urgent need moved it**

War or disaster sometimes moves an object to another country.³

There was no culture of using it there, and then urgency brought it in by the ton, and it got used differently on the spot.

And it stayed after the urgency ended. **Because to the people who grew up then, it was always part of the food.**

The generation clock from Chapter 2 is at work. A taste learned young lasts as long as that person does.

This route has to be stated plainly.

The maker cannot plan it.

What's to be learned here isn't a method. It's a fact. **Where an object goes is not decided by the person who made it.**

The sentence from Chapter 8 appears for the third time. The one who moves it is always the user.

◆ **So what can be done?**

All three are outside your control. Three things still raise the odds.

One. Don't throw it out.

Keeping the failures. A **failure drawer** inside the organisation is enough.

Discarded prototypes, unsold stock, results that came out wrong. A list alone will do. Writing down what is where is sufficient.

Two. Show it outside.

The cheapest and the most effective.

Looked at only from inside, the use doesn't get found. People in the same field all imagine the same slot.

The person who finds the use is not the person who made it.

Show it to someone in a different line of work and they imagine a different slot. And that slot is usually one the maker never considered.

Three. Count the strange uses.

One question to ask customers.

What do you use this for?

When an answer comes back that isn't the intended use, write it down. When the same answer comes back three times, it isn't a quirk. It's a slot.

All three cost almost nothing. **What they require is an organisation that isn't ashamed of failure.** Where failures get hidden, the first one is already impossible.

◆ How this differs from Chapter 8

The two look similar, so they get separated here.

Chapter 8 is the same property going to a different place. The game shoe's toughness and shape were good on the street too.

Chapter 12 is going to a different place because of the property that was a flaw. Not sticking well was the requirement somewhere else.

So Chapter 12 is more dramatic and **harder to plan for.**

Chapter 8 gives signals you can follow. Rising repair requests will tell you. Chapter 12 shows nothing until the signal arrives.

So the prescription in Chapter 12 isn't how to find. It's how not to discard.

◆ The short version

Route	What happened	Plannable?	What you can do
Flaw became requirement	Found a place where the property fits	Partly	Write the place beside each flaw
Rough → comfortable	Excess quality became patina and shape	Yes	Build to the rough standard from the start
Urgency moved it	Used differently	No	Nothing

Route	What happened	Plannable?	What you can do
	in another country		

A flaw is not a property. It's a mismatch between a property and a place.

◆ Sources for this chapter

1. How a weakly adhesive adhesive came to be developed, how long its inventor spent trying to find a use for it inside the company, how another researcher arrived at the application, the test-marketing and formal launch dates, and the total years from discovery to product (Post-it Notes). Only what the manufacturer's material confirms.
2. The release period and original wearers of an air-cushioned-sole boot (Dr. Martens 1460), and when subcultures began wearing it. Only what the

manufacturer's material and contemporaneous records confirm.

3. How a processed food supplied to armed forces became an everyday food in a particular region, and when.

◆ One Line Today

Fold a sheet of paper lengthwise to make two columns.

In the left column, write **five flaws** in what you're making now. Start with the ones you wanted to fix and couldn't.

In the right column, write one line beside each.

Where is this property actually required?

Four of the five can stay blank. **If even one fills in, that one is a place worth testing.**

And there's one more thing you can do today.

Show that sheet to someone in a different line of work.

Not someone in your industry. Someone doing something else entirely.

The person who finds the use is not the person who made it.

Chapter 13 — A Few People Kept It: Sold Little, Sank Deep

◆ When sales and influence come apart

In the back rack of an old record shop there's a record that doesn't sell.

It didn't sell the year it came out. It doesn't sell much now.

And almost everyone who makes music knows it.

This isn't only a music phenomenon. There are books few people read, films few people saw, tools few people used, that sit in the same position.

By sales figures they might as well not exist, and things made out of them keep appearing.

Odd. **Why do sales and influence come apart?**

◆ The risk in this chapter, stated first

This chapter has to be written more carefully than the others.

Stories attach themselves to objects like these. Stories along the lines of "everyone who bought one went on to make something."

Those stories are well made, widely spread, and **have no source.**

Often a remark somebody made in passing got repeated until it hardened into fact. Go looking and the person who first said it never had a basis either.

Widely known does not mean true.

So in this chapter, unverifiable anecdotes were **cut whole rather than reworded.** A hedged sentence gets read as a fact.

Which makes the chapter flatter. That was judged the better price to pay.

What follows is structure without stories.

◆ **The obvious reading — good things get recognized eventually**

Not even half right.

The number of things that went unrecognized and disappeared is overwhelming. And no list of them exists.

The unnamed box from Chapter 4 opens widest here.

What we call "examples of things eventually recognized" are **a list assembled only from the ones that were recognized.**

So what to look for here isn't comfort. **It's the difference between selling little and staying, and selling little and vanishing.**

◆ Width and density

Put two situations side by side.

A million people who liked it once. A thousand people who liked it for life.

Sales are a thousand times larger on the first. So is revenue, so is the talk, so is the ranking.

And twenty years later the one still standing is sometimes the second.

One reason.

Width makes revenue. Density makes lifespan.

Someone who liked it shallowly doesn't pass it on. There isn't enough reason inside them to.

Someone who liked it deeply does. Not once, but repeatedly, over years.

◆ Three things density does

Broken out.

One. It transmits.

Chapter 3 said a default is built not by advertising but by what people who went through before said. The ones who speak are the ones who liked it deeply.

A thousand deep beat a million shallow on volume of speech.

Two. It preserves.

More important.

Someone who liked it deeply doesn't throw it away. They keep the original, repair it when it breaks, hunt for it when it's gone.

Chapter 11 said the late discoveries had **the original still existing** in common. **The few are the ones who kept it.**

So density is a precondition for rediscovery. **Something nobody liked deeply isn't even still around.**

Three. It makes.

Some of the people who liked it deeply use it as material for something new.

Then the original keeps getting cited. Every time something new appears, the original's name gets said once more.

What gets cited doesn't die.

That's the structure behind sales and influence coming apart. A sale happens once. A citation keeps happening.

◆ **Three traps in density**

Read critically here. Read as romance, this chapter becomes a harmful one.

One. Density can't be manufactured.

There's no method for making people like something deeply. If there were, everyone would be using it.

It can, however, be prevented.

Make it too easy and density tends not to form.

Attachment doesn't stick to things that took no effort.

Chapter 8 said patina converts early discomfort into later attachment. The same structure shows here.

We don't know how to create density. We know how to destroy it. Make everything comfortable, change it often, let anyone in.

Two. A few and zero look the same.

Especially from the inside.

Chapter 11's test applies again. Are they saying it, or using it? One more indicator can be added.

Do they come back?

If the number is small but the same people return, that's density. If only new people come and never return, that isn't density. That's curiosity.

This number is easy to count and costs nothing to count.

Three. Density usually doesn't feed you.

The passage in this chapter that has to be most honest.

Among examples in this territory, the maker was often poor. By the time the influence had grown, that person was gone or doing something else.

Density gives lifespan. It doesn't give a living.

So "aim for density" cannot be this chapter's lesson.

◆ Then what is being asked?

Three things.

One. Count the density.

Knowing whether it's there comes first. Returns, repeat purchases, people who contact you directly. All easy to count.

Two. Don't break the line to those few.

The most practical sentence in this chapter.

When a rediscovery happens, those few are the bridge. If the line is broken, the world can arrive and there's no way across.

Keep the list, send them something, make a place to meet.

The smaller the number the easier this is, and if it isn't done while it's small it can't be done later.

Three. Keep the order.

The conclusion.

Width can be bought later. Density cannot.

When money appears, advertising buys width. That's what advertising is for. Nobody can buy people who like something deeply.

So the order is fixed. **Density first, width second.**

Go in the reverse order and when the width goes out nothing remains. Most of what's in Part Two was in the reverse order.

◆ **The short version**

Question	This chapter's answer
Why do sales and influence split	Width makes revenue, density makes lifespan
What density does	Transmits · preserves · makes
Why does preserving matter	Without survival, rediscovery is impossible
Can density be made	No. It can be destroyed

Question	This chapter's answer
A few versus zero	Do they come back?
Can you live on density	Usually not. Lifespan yes, a living no
So what do you do	Count it, keep the line, build density first

◆ Sources for this chapter

This chapter names no specific case.

Several widely told examples exist for this pattern, and the central claim of those stories could not be confirmed against a primary source. Unconfirmed anecdotes were removed entirely rather than softened.

For a name to go into the text, the following would have to be confirmed: actual sales at release, when the influence grew, and a primary basis for the event said to connect the two.

◆ One Line Today

Think of one thing you like **deeply** that most people don't know. A book, music, a shop, a tool. Anything.

Count two things.

First, how many times have you told someone about it?

Second, did anyone actually try it because you told them?

The first number is usually larger than expected. **People talk about what they like deeply. Nobody has to ask them to.**

Then ask the same question about your own work.

Not counting me, how many people have spoken about what I made more than once?

If none, there's no density yet. **If there's even one, save that person's contact details now.**

When the world eventually arrives, that person is the bridge.

Part Five • Fourth Path • Sat a Long Time, Then Broke Out

◆ The path that doesn't fit the table

Two chapters. The shortest part of this book, and the center of gravity is here.

Bring back the table from Chapter 4.

The two questions were whether it broke out and whether it's still here. This path doesn't fit into the four boxes they make.

Something that sat quietly for a long time and suddenly broke out.

◆ **What's different from the third path**

It looks like the late arrivals of Part Four. One thing is decisive.

	③ Arrived late	④ Sat, then broke out
Meanwhile	Forgotten	Still selling
The maker	Usually gone	Alive
Who collects	Someone else	The maker

Part Four said it: for the late arrivals the maker was often not there. When the world came, there was nobody to receive it.

Only on this path does the maker collect.

Which makes it the only path with practical meaning for someone making something.

◆ **A request about reading order**

The two chapters are opposite in nature.

Chapter 14 looks at what happens. It's the hopeful one.

Chapter 15 looks at why most can't catch it. It's the conditions one.

One request.

Read them in one sitting.

Read Chapter 14 alone and this part becomes comfort.

And comfort makes a person feel better and then changes nothing.

Chapter 15 is where the work comes from.

◆ **The limit of this part**

This is the part of the book that is hardest to verify.

When something broke out is confirmable in records.

Charts, revenue, visitor counts. **Why it broke out is not confirmable.**

Afterwards the explanations are abundant. Articles appear, analyses appear, reasons get organised.

Those explanations are almost all attached afterwards.

Write a retrofitted explanation as a cause and this part becomes fiction.

So in this part it's written this way.

What happened is recorded. That it was the cause is not.

For a reader that can be frustrating. **The frustration is what accuracy costs.**

Chapter 14 — The Moment Something Already There Gets Found

◆ The owner doesn't know why

One day a queue forms outside an old shop.

The shop changed nothing. Same menu, same sign, same owner.

And the owner doesn't know what happened.

The same line always follows this scene.

| We've been doing what we always do.

Odd.

In Part Four the world took ten years to arrive. Here it arrives in a few days.

Same object, same place. Why does it take ten years sometimes and one night others?

◆ **The obvious reading — a sudden break-out is luck**

Half right.

It is luck. It isn't something you can plan.

But there's an optical illusion hidden in the word.

It didn't break out suddenly.

That object had been in that spot for ten years, twenty.

What appeared suddenly wasn't the object. It was the attention.

So put precisely:

A discovery isn't an event. It's a connection.

Somebody moved it into a place where other people look.
That moving happens in an instant, so it looks sudden.

The object didn't move. The gaze moved.

◆ **Four carriers of discovery**

Chapter 11 sorted the carriers of late arrival into three.
Here they split differently. These are the fast ones.

One. It appeared on a screen.

An object gets used in a drama or a film and people who
watched go looking. A song used in one scene returning to
the charts is the same structure.¹

There's one very clear example.

A singer released a song a long time ago. That song was
used in one scene of a drama season.¹

A few weeks later it was **number one on the national chart. Thirty-seven years after it was released.**¹

The gap between that singer's previous number one and this one was forty-four years, **the longest gap in that chart's history.**¹

The singer did nothing during any of it. No re-recording, no re-release, no promotion.

What matters is that **it wasn't advertising.**

An object that appeared in an advertisement gets processed as advertising. An object that was inside a story gets processed as part of that story.

Two. A different generation saw it as new.

This one happens most often and is understood least.

That song is the example. Most of the people who put it at number one hadn't been born when it first came out.

To them it wasn't an old song. It was a song they were hearing for the first time.

To someone seeing it for the first time, an old thing is a new thing.

Cameras that use film, music on a disc, tools used by hand. To someone who grew up with them they're old objects; to someone meeting them for the first time they're **something never tried.**

What separates old from new isn't in the object. It's in the age of the person looking.

The generation clock from Chapter 2 comes full circle here. When a generation turns, its things go down. One more generation and those things are new again.

Three. One person carried it.

Someone in a place many people watch is seen using it.

This carrier is faster than the other two, and shallower. When that person's attention moves, it often moves with them.

Four. Circumstances made it necessary again.

When prices rise, when supply breaks, when people start wanting something else, an older way becomes the answer.

Repairing rather than replacing, using something for a long time, making it yourself. When conditions get harder, the value of these rises.

Tie the four together in one line.

None of the four was done by the maker.

Chapter 8 said the user moves the object. Chapter 12 said the person who finds the use is not the person who made it.

That's the third time. Not a coincidence — it's the spine of this book.

But here Part Five's own difference appears.

**The maker didn't do it, and it doesn't happen
without the maker.**

◆ **A wave is not only good news**

Here the real content of this chapter starts.

What happens when a wave arrives is rarely discussed. Everyone aims at that moment, so nobody looks past it.

A wave breaks whatever wasn't ready. Four things arrive at once.

One. Orders exceed what you can make.

In Chapter 7 things died by growing. This is the opposite direction. Ten times the volume arrives and the equipment

and the people are unchanged.

Two. A long stock-out moves the attention on.

A wave doesn't wait. Someone who couldn't buy rarely waits until next month.

Three. Scaling up in a hurry shakes the quality.

And this is the part that hurts.

The value of that object was its quality.

The reason it lasted was consistency, and consistency breaks while you're scaling to catch the wave.

Four. New customers collide with old ones.

The quietest and the deepest loss.

The people who always came can't get in. No table, no stock, a long queue. And they don't complain. **They just stop coming.**

A few months after the wave, the new customers are all gone. And the old customers who should still be there left some time ago.

This is how the place after a wave ends up worse than before it.

◆ **Three rules for when a wave arrives**

Three things have to be decided in advance. Deciding after the wave arrives is too late.

One. Take care of the old customers first.

The wave passes; the old customers are what remains.

Concretely, it means setting aside their share. Holding reservations, holding quantity, keeping a separate channel open.

Turning away a new customer feels wasteful. Bearing that feeling is the whole of this rule.

Two. Scale up, but reversibly.

Chapter 7's arithmetic applies exactly.

Whether this wave is need demand or talk demand can't be known now. And it's usually talk demand.

So **scale up the reversible things first**. More people, longer hours, outside help. Buying equipment and adding space comes last.

Three. Buy a bridge with what the wave pays.

The third time this prescription appears in this book.

Chapter 5 said to buy a position with fad money. Chapter 7 said that when it's going well, add bridges rather than locations.

Here it comes again. **Three appearances means this is the only thing this book actually says.**

◆ **Nobody knows why it broke out**

To close this chapter honestly.

After it breaks out, explanations are everywhere.

They are almost all attached afterwards.

Several places had the same conditions at the same time and one broke out. **Then those conditions are not the cause.**

So copying a case that broke out is dangerous. **What you'd be copying is a condition, not a cause.**

What this book can say ends here.

What happened can be recorded. That it was the cause cannot.

And because of that limit, the next chapter is necessary.

If the cause is unknown, the question has to change.

Not how to make it break out, but what it takes to be standing there when it does.

◆ The short version

Question	This chapter's answer
Was it really sudden	No. What appeared suddenly was attention, not the object
What is a discovery	Not an event — a connection . The gaze moved
Four carriers	A screen · a different generation · one person · circumstances
In common	None of the four was done by the maker
The risk of a wave	Capacity · stock-outs · quality · old customers leaving

Question	This chapter's answer
Three rules	Old customers first · reversible scaling · buy a bridge
Why did it break out	Can't be confirmed. The explanations come afterwards

◆ Sources for this chapter

1. For a song released long ago that reached number one after being used in a screen work (Kate Bush, "Running Up That Hill"): the original release date, when it was used, when it reached number one, the number of years between release and number one, and the gap from that singer's previous number one. Only what the national official chart records confirm.

This chapter does not identify a cause of rediscovery. The cases that did not get rediscovered under the same conditions can't be counted.

◆ One Line Today

Think of an object or a shop you've been seeing a lot of lately. Ideally one that seems new, that younger people talk about.

Then **find out when it was made.**

Most people are surprised. It's usually old.

Then write two things.

First, where had it been all that time?

Second, what moved it in front of people? A screen, a different generation, one person, or circumstances?

Then one last question.

Why hadn't it disappeared before then?

The answer to that question is the next chapter. **Nobody knows how to make a wave. How to be standing there**

when one arrives can be known.

Chapter 15 — Only What Endured Catches the Wave: Why New Products Can't

◆ The other nine endured too

There's a street with several old shops on it.

Say a queue forms at one of them. People come and take photographs, an article appears, the story spreads.

And this line follows.

So holding on does work.

The other shops on that street held on too. The same years, in the same place, with the same diligence.

Nothing happened to them.

This chapter has to start there.

◆ **The obvious reading — hold on and it comes eventually**

Other chapters in this book said "half right."

That can't be written here.

This one is barely right at all.

Far more things hold on and quietly disappear with nothing happening. And nothing gets written about them.

The unnamed box from Chapter 4 is at its widest here.

So are Parts Four and Five a lie? No. The sentence just has to be written accurately.

Holding on doesn't make it break out. But only what held on can catch it.

The difference between those two sentences is this entire chapter.

◆ It has to be there, and being there isn't enough

There are two kinds of condition.

Conditions **without which it cannot happen**, and conditions **which make it happen**.

Holding on is the first kind.

Without it, never. With it, not necessarily.

Why the distinction matters.

Take it as the second kind and a person receives a false comfort. They're holding on, so surely one day. And that thought carries the day. And when ten years pass and nothing has happened, they break.

Take it as the first kind and the question changes.

Holding on is the baseline, so **what else has to be there?**

If one in ten of the ones who held on caught it, what was different about that one? The rest of this chapter is the answer.

◆ **Why new products can't catch it**

The title's question first.

What people look for when a wave comes is **something old**. Three of the four carriers in Chapter 14 have oldness as a condition.

And oldness can't be manufactured.

What if you make a new one in the old way? The old shape, an old name, the feeling of that era.

People mostly tell the difference. There's a reason.

Oldness comes with evidence, and something newly

made has none.

The evidence is things like this.

Objects actually made back then, still surviving. The memories of people who used it a long time. Something that hasn't changed. The fact that the same thing is in a photograph from ten years ago.

All of that **only comes into existence with the passage of time.**

However much money there is, passed time can't be bought. So oldness is the one asset a newcomer can never take.

The drawback is that it takes ten years to make. The advantage is that nobody can overtake you.

◆ **What separates the ones that held on**

The core of this chapter. Four conditions.

One. It was there and it was findable

Being there and not findable is the same as not being there.

A wave is fast. When somebody hears about it and goes looking, **it has to come up right away.**

And the longer something has held on, the worse this tends to be.

The name changed a few times, the location moved several times, nothing is written down anywhere.

Chapter 13 said not to break the line to the few. Here it becomes **leave one line open to the world.**

Not changing the name, not moving, being findable when searched. **All three cost almost nothing and are fatal if skipped.**

Two. It was there and it was recognizable

Shape, from Chapter 9, pays here.

When a wave comes, people don't look for long. It has to be recognizable while they go past.

Places that changed a little each year are at a disadvantage. Nothing about them is old, because everything was changed a little.

There has to be something that shows that thing then is this thing now.

Three. The story was still there

When a wave comes, people look for the story.

Why it's old, who started it, what hasn't changed. That story spreads and the wave gets bigger.

Without a story it's just an old shop.

And a story can't be made afterwards. That's why Chapter 11 said to leave a record.

Old photographs, old ledgers, the first thing ever made, the record of changes. **Storing them costs almost**

nothing, and skipping it can't be undone later.

Four. There was a body able to receive it

The cruellest condition.

Shrink too far and a wave arrives and you can't take it. No people, no capacity, no way to process the orders.

And too large doesn't work either. As Chapter 7 showed, a large body can't sit through a quiet decade.

So the actual task is this.

Setting a size small enough to survive a quiet ten years, and large enough to receive one sudden one.

That size is calculable. Write down what has to leave every month, and lower it.

And that is the most practical number in this entire book.

◆ Redefining what holding on means

One direction has to change here.

Think of holding on as waiting and you can't do it.

Almost nobody can wait ten years. Waiting shaves a person down a little at a time.

So how did the ones that lasted do it?

They weren't waiting.

**Not holding on while waiting for a wave, but
holding on in a state that doesn't require one.**

Building a state that turns by itself, however small.

The renewing demand from Chapter 3. The annual cycle from Chapter 10. The few who come back from Chapter 13.

None of the three is large. None of the three goes out either.

Build that state and holding on stops being endurance and becomes just living.

And in that state, no wave is not a loss.

Aim at a wave and ten years without one is a total loss.

Treat a wave as a bonus and ten years without one is just ten years.

That difference is what separates people who actually last from people who don't.

◆ **When it doesn't come**

The honest ending.

You can have all four and no wave comes. **And usually none comes.**

So was the preparation wasted?

No. And the reason is what this chapter most wants to say.

Look at the four again.

Being there and findable. Being there and recognizable.

Having the story. Having a body that fits.

All four are worth something with no wave at all.

Findable means people come in ordinary times.

Recognizable means less spent on advertising. A story means whoever came once comes again. A fitting body means not being short of breath every month.

Because preparing for a wave and simply being in good shape are the same thing, it isn't wasted when no wave comes.

This is why this part isn't comfort.

Comfort changes nothing and improves the mood. **These four have work attached to them today, and they pay**

with or without a wave.

◆ The short version

Question	This chapter's answer
Does holding on bring it	No. Only what held on can catch it
Why can't new products	Oldness comes with evidence . New has none
Condition one	Findable — name, place, searchable
Condition two	Recognizable — the shape didn't change
Condition three	The story survived — the records weren't discarded
Condition four	A body able to receive — the size was set
How do you hold on	Not waiting — in a state that needs no wave

Question	This chapter's answer
If it doesn't come	All four pay without a wave. It isn't wasted

◆ Sources for this chapter

This chapter names no specific case.

The number of places that met the same conditions and were never rediscovered can't be counted. Listing only the successes without knowing that number would reverse this chapter's argument.

The four conditions are traits observed in cases that were rediscovered, **not a claim that those conditions cause rediscovery.**

◆ One Line Today

Write down one number.

What has to leave every month to keep the thing you do alive?

Rent, people, minimum materials, the costs that can't be dropped. Count only what leaves when revenue is zero.

That number is the most important number in this book.
That number decides how many years you can last.

When it's written, do one more thing.

To cut this number to a third, what would have to be given up?

Write the list. You don't have to give anything up.

Written down, it means you've decided in advance what goes first if things get hard.

Then one last question.

Can you last ten years on that number?

If not, what needs fixing now isn't the product. It's the number. **Making a good object matters less than making sure the object is still here in ten years.**

Part Six · So What Do You Make?

◆ From here it's short

Five chapters, and the shortest in the book.

There's a reason.

A checklist is not an explanation.

The explaining was done by the previous five parts.

Explaining again here adds length and no use.

◆ Two rules

One. No new concepts.

If a word appears for the first time in Part Six, it means the previous five parts were thin. Only what has already appeared gets used here.

The repetition isn't hidden. **A sentence that appears three times means it's the only thing this book actually says.**

Two. No names.

Same as Part One. No company names, no product names.

Parts Two through Five needed names. They were evidence. Part Six is not a place for evidence. **It's a place for listing the work.**

And Part One and Part Six have to age more slowly than anything else here.

◆ **The order**

Chapter	What it does
16	Read — what is blocked right now
17	Break out — make a reason to buy today
18	Land — lay the four bridges in order
19	Look far — sit on what won't move
20	Who has the advantage — this book's answer

Chapter 17 comes before 18 because that's the order most people do it in.

The argument of this part is to do them at the same time.

As Chapter 7 showed, bridges are only cheap while the talk is alive. Think about landing after breaking out and it's already expensive.

Please read 17 and 18 together.

Chapter 16 — Reading the Present: Three to Watch, Three to Ignore

◆ Everyone is looking at the same screen

Chapter 7 had three of the same signboard on one street. The three people who opened them didn't know each other.

They were all looking at the same screen.

There are screens that tell you what's doing well. Rankings, search terms, summary articles.

All three looked. All three concluded the same thing.

Something is odd here. **How can a decision made from information anyone can see be better than anyone else's?**

◆ Three to ignore

One. Rankings.

A ranking shows what sold last month. **It's an instrument for looking backwards, not forwards.**

And there's a bigger problem. Everybody looks at the same ranking. A judgment made from it is the same judgment everyone else made.

Two. Anything that already has a name.

Something having a name means many people already recognized it. It also means it's been discussed enough times to be worth naming.

The moment a name appears is already late.

Three. What someone else already succeeded at.

As Chapter 14 showed, looking at a success shows you conditions, not causes. There's no record of the other places that met the same conditions.

The three have one thing in common.

All three are things that already happened.

◆ Three to watch

One. What people are patching by hand.

The most useful tool in this chapter.

People don't endure inconvenience. **They solve it badly.**

Tape stuck over something. Two things used together. A step done in a strange order. Somebody's object used for something else.

Where there's a patch, there is a gap.

And this signal has a large advantage. **Unlike a ranking, it is happening now.**

Two. What suddenly got cheap.

The first carrier from Chapter 11.

Hold a list of what has to fall and by how much for something to work, and you'll recognize it. Without the list, the price falls and you don't notice.

Three. Where a rule changed.

A permission is granted, something is prohibited, a standard changes, and a slot appears or disappears.

Rule changes have an unusual property. **They're announced in advance.** This is reading, not forecasting.

◆ What reading means

Put together:

Reading the present is not guessing what will rise.

It's seeing what is blocked right now.

The difference matters.

Guessing what will rise means **being faster than others.**

The fast side is the side with money and information.

Seeing what's blocked doesn't require speed. **It requires looking closely.** And looking closely costs nothing.

Chapters 19 and 20 come out of that sentence.

◆ The checklist

1. For one week, write down what people say they're annoyed by – ten of them

Count your own. Count what you overheard

2. Beside each, write how they're currently coping

3. Mark the ones with a hand-made

patch

→ that's a gap

4. Among those, mark the ones with no name yet

→ that's a gap you're not late for

5. For what's left, ask two things

What would have to get cheaper for this to be solved?

What rule would have to change for this to be solved?

None of the five costs money. **They cost a week and one sheet of paper.**

◆ **The short version**

	Ignore	Watch
One	Rankings	What people are patching by hand
Two	Anything already named	What suddenly got cheap
Three	Someone else's success	Where a rule changed
Timing	Already happened	Happening now
What it takes	Fast information	Close observation

A ranking is the past. An annoyance is the present.

◆ One Line Today

For one day, count one thing.

Scenes of people patching an inconvenience by hand.

At home, on the street, at work. Tape, rubber bands, sticky notes, doing something twice, a strange order.

Three is enough.

Then write one line for each.

Why has nobody made this properly yet?

The answer is usually one of three. **Too small, no money in it, or nobody looked.**

If it's the third, the seat is empty.

Chapter 17 — How to Break Out: Five Ways to Make a Reason to Buy Today

◆ Good, and not selling

Sometimes a good object doesn't sell.

Everyone who has tried it says it's good. Everyone nods when they hear the explanation.

And nobody buys it.

Look closely at objects like this and they have one thing in common.

"Why buy this" has an answer. "Why buy this now" doesn't.

People buy later what they can buy later. And later mostly doesn't arrive.

What a bestseller does is answer the second question.

◆ **Five reasons to buy today**

There are only five.

One. A deadline. You can only get it until a date.

Two. Scarcity. You might not be able to get one.

Three. A season. Now is the time.

Four. Visibility. Other people see it. Not having it now means not showing it now.

Five. Others already bought. Not buying leaves you in the position of behind.

The five have something in common.

All five are about time.

Not one of them is about the object being good. **Breaking out isn't boasting about the object. It's manufacturing time.**

◆ **But four of them wear out**

The criticism goes here immediately.

Chapter 5 said talk decreases when used. **These devices decrease when used too.**

A deadline every time isn't a deadline. A shortage every time isn't a shortage.

Used on the same person a second time it's half as strong, and the third time it works backwards, because they feel handled.

One of the five doesn't wear out.

The season.

The reason is in Chapter 10. The calendar rebuilds it every year. December returns whether the maker does anything or not.

Lay the five out by cost and lifespan and they separate.

Device	Cost to build	Wears out?	How many times
Deadline	Low	Wears fast	A few
Scarcity	Medium. It has to be genuinely short	Wears out	Few
Season	None. The calendar provides it	Doesn't wear	Unlimited
Visibility	Costs design	Doesn't wear	Continuous
Others already bought	Hardest at the start	Doesn't wear	Continuous

The table gives an order.

Season, visibility and others-already-bought are reusable devices. Deadline and scarcity are cards you play once.

Most people do the reverse. They keep using deadlines and shortages and never build a season.

Because they start with whichever is easiest to use.

◆ **A warning attached to scarcity**

Scarcity is especially dangerous. Chapter 7 covered it.

The value of scarcity comes from **the fact that somebody went without**. And that is an asset that disappears when supply increases.

Wanting to scale up after breaking out on scarcity is natural. **You only have to know that the decision is a decision to spend your own asset.**

◆ Two things to write before breaking out

The actual work of this chapter is these two.

One. Write down the ending date.

The second time this appears, after Chapters 5 and 7.

Not wanting to write a date is normal. **Don't write it and the default becomes "indefinitely," and that default is what ruins people.**

Two. Decide now which of the four bridges you'll lay.

Deciding after it breaks is too late.

Chapter 7 put it plainly. **The real value of a fad isn't the revenue. It's that for a while, people are looking.** Carve a shape while nobody is looking and nobody learns it.

So 17 and 18 aren't a sequence. They're simultaneous.

◆ The checklist

1. Is there a reason to buy today?

If not, pick one of the five

2. Write whether what you picked wears out

If it does, decide in advance how many times you'll use it

3. Write the ending date

Then set the payback period shorter than that

4. Decide now which of the four bridges you'll lay

→ go to Chapter 18

◆ The short version

Question	This chapter's answer
What a bestseller answers	Not why buy — why buy now
The five	Deadline · scarcity · season · visibility · others already bought
In common	All five are about time
Wears out	Deadline · scarcity. Not twice on the same person
Doesn't wear out	Season · visibility · others already bought
Do first	Write the ending date, and pick the bridge

Breaking out isn't boasting about the object. It's manufacturing time.

◆ One Line Today

Stand in front of what you're making and say one sentence out loud.

Why should someone buy this today rather than next month?

If no answer comes immediately, it isn't ready to break out. **Not because the object is bad, but because there's no time in it.**

If an answer came, check one more thing.

Can you use that same answer next year?

If you can, you built a reusable device. If you can't, you played a one-time card — **and that's fine. You only have to know there aren't many of them.**

Chapter 18 — How to Land: The Order for Laying the Four Bridges

◆ There is an order

Chapter 2 named the four bridges. Part Three showed how each one actually gets laid.

Here, only **the order**.

You can't lay all four at once. And in the wrong order they don't hold.

Repeat → Shape → Patina →
Handoff

Each position has a reason.

◆ Why Repeat is first

An object nobody buys twice has no use for the other three.

Carve a shape into something sold once and people get one chance to see that shape.

Chapter 9 said shape is built by accumulation.

Accumulating means seeing it many times, and seeing it many times means buying it many times.

And Repeat is **the cheapest**.

Pick one of the four in Chapter 10. Attach to a date that already exists, design the consumption rate, let the object announce its replacement time, or make something in yearly units.

All four are far cheaper than making a season.

◆ **Why Shape is second**

Once Repeat exists, people see the thing many times.

That's when a shape starts to accumulate.

Lay Shape first and what happens?

A shape on something nobody looks at twice doesn't accumulate. You spend and nothing stays.

The three conditions from Chapter 9 apply directly.

Drawable, unchanging, from function.

And there's a cheapest way to lay Shape.

Pick one thing and don't change it.

One colour, one form, one sound. **Deciding costs nothing. Not changing it takes effort.**

◆ **Why Patina is third**

There's a reason not to lay Patina first.

Patina reduces repeat purchases.

Things used for a long time sell less often. Chapter 8 said so.

So laying Patina first cuts revenue first. You can't survive in that state.

Only once Repeat is secured can Patina be afforded.

There's a cheapest way here too.

Set up somewhere to get it repaired.

No redesign needed. Leave the object as it is and simply accept repairs.

Chapter 8 said repair requests are a signal, not a cost.

Repairing gets you two things at once: patina, and information about whether the object is changing lanes.

◆ **Why Handoff is fourth**

Handoff needs all three of the others.

To pass it on it has to **not break**. Patina comes first.

Whatever was passed on has to **work with what's**

current. Shape and compatibility come first. Whatever was passed on has to **have a use.** Repeat comes first.

Missing any one of the three and the inherited object goes to storage.

And the cheapest way to lay Handoff:

Make a place to write a name and a date.

Chapter 8 said what gets handed down isn't the object but the time spent with it. **Time attaches where memory can attach.**

◆ **When they have to be laid**

Before it breaks out.

Laying them after costs more, for three reasons.

One. People have already decided what the object is.

Change it later and it's a different object.

Two. When revenue is large you can't decide to reduce it. All four bridges reduce current revenue. Reducing a small number and reducing a large number are different weights of decision.

Three. The organisation has grown and can't change.
The more that's been settled, the more changing costs.

So 17 and 18 have to happen at the same time.

◆ **Why doesn't everyone do it?**

Repeating Chapter 8.

All four bridges **reduce current revenue.**

The price can fall, handing down replaces buying, keeping compatibility blocks changes, long use means fewer sales.

Judged by the quarter, not laying them is always right.

Bridges aren't expensive. They're just hard to

decide on, because they reduce revenue now.

That sentence is where Part Two and Part Three separate.
And it's the only genuinely hard thing in this book.

◆ Check yourself

Answer yes or no.

Bridge	The question	Yes/No
Repeat	When the time comes, do people buy it again?	
Shape	Take the label off — is it recognized?	
Patina	Is it better at five years old than new?	
Handoff	Can it be given to someone	

Bridge	The question	Yes/No
	else?	
Number of yes	What it means	
0	It's a product for this quarter	
1	It lasts a season	
2 or more	It might stay	

As Chapter 2 said. **Two or more of the four and it tends to last.**

◆ The checklist

1. Count how many yes you have now
2. If it's 0 or 1, start with Repeat
Attaching to an existing date is
the cheapest

3. Once Repeat holds, pick one element of Shape

Then don't change it for at least three years

4. Once Repeat and Shape have settled, start accepting repairs

You get patina and information at the same time

5. When all three exist, make a place to write a name

◆ The short version

Bridge	Why that position	The cheapest way to lay it
Repeat	Without it the other three are useless	Attach to a date that exists

Bridge	Why that position	The cheapest way to lay it
Shape	It has to be seen many times to accumulate	Pick one and don't change it
Patina	It cuts repeat sales, so Repeat comes first	Set up repairs
Handoff	Needs all three of the others	Make a place to write a name

Look at what laying them costs and there's a pattern.

None of them costs much money.

◆ One Line Today

Answer the check above. Four lines and it's done.

If you got 0 or 1 yes, that's normal. Most objects are like that, and everything in Part Two was too.

Then decide one thing.

Which of the four will you lay first?

Once decided, write down **one thing you can do this month** for that one.

Attaching to an existing date. Fixing one colour.

Announcing that you'll repair it. Adding a place to write a name.

All four are the size of something you can start this month. The hard part isn't starting. **It's not changing it for three years.**

Chapter 19 — Seeing the Future: Read It in What Won't Change

◆ Two questions

Someone trying to see ahead usually asks this.

What will be different in ten years?

There's a problem with that question.

Nobody knows the answer.

And a larger problem. Even getting it right, you can't win the contest of getting it right.

Knowing first requires more information than others and moving faster than others. **That contest is won by whoever already had both.**

Invert the question and the board changes.

What will people still be doing exactly the same way in ten years?

That question has an answer. And the answer **is not a secret.**

◆ The obvious reading — seeing the future means guessing right

Not even half right.

Look at the people who made the things that lasted and almost none of them guessed what was coming.

They did something else.

They picked one thing people would keep doing, and sat on it.

So it has to be written this way.

Seeing the future isn't knowing what will come. It's knowing what won't go.

Those two differ completely in difficulty.

Nobody knows what will come. **Everybody knows what won't go.**

◆ **The list of what won't change**

Start from the need clock in Chapter 2.

Cold. Hungry. Sleepy. Hurting. Bored. Lonely. Wanting to be seen. Wanting to pass something on.

A few more can be added.

Short of time. Short of money. Not sure what to choose. Wanting to see people. Wanting to be alone. Wanting a child to do well. A parent is ill. Doing something for the first time is frightening.

The list has a quality.

It's dull.

Nothing is new, nothing is announceable, nobody is surprised.

And the things that lasted are standing on that dull list.

◆ **One test**

Whether something belongs on the list is settled by one question.

Did people a hundred years ago want this? Will people a hundred years from now want it?

Yes to both is a **need**. No to either is a **method**.

This is the distinction that recurs most often in this book.

The vanished things in Chapter 6 were holding methods.
The surviving things in Chapter 8 moved across to needs.

The need doesn't change. The method of meeting it does.

◆ **Build one table**

The actual work of this chapter is one table.

The need that doesn't change	The current method	When does the method change?
Getting word to someone far away		
Keeping food from spoiling		
Learning something for the first time		

The need that
doesn't change

The current
method

When does the
method change?

Getting a child to
sleep

Deciding what to
buy

The left column doesn't change. It was there a hundred years ago and will be there in a hundred.

The middle column has changed repeatedly and will change again.

Fill it in and two things become visible.

One. Which column your work is in.

In the left column, it can last. In the middle column, that method's lifespan is your lifespan.

Two. What the middle column could turn into.

Trying to fill the right column usually stalls. **Stalling is normal.** As Chapter 6 showed, skipping is hard to predict.

One thing can still be written. **Write the most inconvenient part of the current method.** When a method changes, it usually changes there.

◆ So what do you make?

The answer becomes simple.

Pick something people will still be doing the same way in ten years. Make that thing slightly better.

"Slightly" matters.

Try to change it greatly and you're changing the method, and changing the method easily becomes the third case in Chapter 6. The place where something nobody asked for gets pushed.

Making something slightly better is work people already asked for.

The hand-made patches in Chapter 16 are the signal. That someone is patching it also means **they're still doing that**

thing.

◆ **The limit of this method**

Stated plainly.

Sitting on what won't change is no guarantee of doing well.

Someone may already be sitting there. The default from Chapter 3 may be held by somebody else.

And it takes a long time.

Earning a place on something unchanging takes time. It isn't fast.

So what this method gives isn't success.

It gives a state in which you don't have to guess right.

You don't have to be anxious every January about what's coming. **Sit on what won't go, and whatever comes, you live underneath it.**

◆ **The short version**

Question	This chapter's answer
The usual question	What will be different in ten years
This book's question	What will people still be doing the same way
Seeing the future is	Not knowing what will come — knowing what won't go
Why this side	Nobody knows what's coming; everybody knows what won't go
The test	Wanted a hundred years ago and a hundred years from now?

Question	This chapter's answer
What to make	Make that thing slightly better
What it gives	Not success — not having to guess right

**The list of what won't change isn't a secret.
Everybody knows it, and it's dull, so nobody uses it.**

◆ One Line Today

Draw a table with three columns.

Left column: five needs that don't change. Use the test.

Wanted a hundred years ago, wanted a hundred years from now.

Middle column: what you currently do each of them with.

Right column: write only one thing. **The most inconvenient part of the current method.**

When it's filled, mark which column your own work is in.

Left column, or middle column?

Being in the middle column isn't wrong. Most work is there.

You only have to know that the lifespan of that method is your lifespan. And how to move across to the left column is in Part Three.

Chapter 20 — A Game That Favours Whoever Started Late

◆ The ages of the things in this book

Having read this far, there's something you can count.

How old the things in this book were.

The ones that vanished in Part Two were mostly young. They reached a peak in a few years and were gone in a few more.

The ones that stayed in Parts Three, Four and Five were mostly old. And looking at why they stayed, **it wasn't because they were fast.**

Almost none of them stayed by arriving first. **They stayed by not disappearing.**

Odd.

We're taught we live in a world where the fast side wins.
And in the list of things that lasted, speed barely appears.

◆ **There are two games**

What looks like one market is two games running at once.

The speed game. Whoever arrives first takes it. **The stay game.** Whoever has been there longest takes it.

	The speed game	The stay game
What's contested	Who is first	Who is still here
What it takes to win	Capital · information · people · luck	Not quitting
Can you have it in advance	Yes	No
When does the prize come	Soon	Late. Maybe never
Is it crowded	Crowded	Empty

The third row is the whole chapter.

What the speed game needs **can already be in your hands before you start.** Someone with money starts with money; someone with information starts with it.

What the stay game needs cannot be held in advance. **It only accumulates from today.**

The speed game is already decided at the starting line. In the stay game everyone starts level.

And one more thing attaches.

Whoever started first also goes to zero if they quit.

Twenty years ends and those twenty years are gone. In the stay game you can't put your accumulation in storage. **It's only still there while you're still there.**

◆ **Why is this side empty?**

If the stay game is that favourable, why is it empty?

This book has answered three times.

Chapter 3. Renewing demand doesn't grow. No growth rate, nothing to announce. **Chapter 13.** Density gives lifespan and doesn't give a living. **Chapter 15.** Even with all four conditions, most never get a wave.

All three are true. And all three drive people away.

This position isn't uncontested because the barrier is high. It's uncontested because it looks unappealing.

That sentence, from Chapter 3.

And it actually matters to someone starting late.

Large capital doesn't enter a position that doesn't grow. Its reason for staying out is rational, so it will keep staying out.

◆ Not planned. Just never gone

The most important observation in this book.

Of everything in Parts Three through Five, **almost none of it started out trying to make something that lasts.**

They were all built to solve a problem of their moment. The game shoe was for the game; the work boot was for the work.

And they didn't disappear. And so they became old.

Most steady sellers were not planned. They just never disappeared.

If that sentence is true, the goal has to be reset.

"Make something that lasts" can only be scored ten years from now. Nobody can sustain a goal they can't check for ten years.

So what's the goal?

◆ One question to ask

Reduce this whole book to one question and it's this.

Not what will rise, but will I still be doing this in ten years.

That question can be answered today. No ten-year wait.

And work you can answer yes to has a character.

It isn't fun work.

Fun wears out. Same as the talk in Chapter 5. It decreases when used. Work begun for fun gets abandoned the day it stops being fun.

Work you say yes about is a different kind.

It's work that keeps nagging at you.

Work you keep coming back to after it's settled. Work where seeing someone else do it carelessly makes you

angry. Work you do even when there's no money in it.

Work other people ask why you bother about.

Staying a long time in work like that isn't difficult. **It isn't endurance. You just find yourself still doing it.**

Chapter 15 redefined holding on. Not waiting for a wave but being in a state that doesn't require one.

That state has another name, and this is it.

◆ **Three reasons late is better**

Three.

One. The stay game counts from today.

Starting late is not a loss. And whoever started first goes to zero if they quit.

Two. Someone starting late can start small.

Bring back the number from Chapter 15. What leaves every month when revenue is zero.

The lower that number the longer you last. **And someone starting late finds it easy to keep that number low.**

Little to protect, no scale to maintain, no money owed back. **Having little right now is, here, an advantage.**

Three. Someone starting late has read Part Two.

They start knowing how the ones ahead collapsed.

They don't mistake talk demand for need demand, they don't sign a lease longer than the fad, and when things go well they can add bridges instead of locations.

This is information the ones ahead could not buy.

When they were living through it, it hadn't happened yet.

◆ **Favourable doesn't mean easy**

The honest ending.

In the stay game the prize comes late. And as Chapter 15 said, **usually it doesn't come.**

You can do ten years and have nothing happen. That is the normal result of this game.

So this book closes by confirming why those ten years aren't wasted.

The four from Chapter 15.

Being there and findable. Being there and recognizable. Having the story. Having a body that fits.

All four pay without a wave.

And so do the four bridges.

Bought again when the time comes. Recognized with the label off. Better with use. Passable to someone else.

An object with those four is a good object even if it never becomes famous.

Because preparing for a wave and simply being in good shape are the same thing, it isn't wasted when no wave comes.

That's the whole of what this book can promise. **And it's a promise that can be kept.**

◆ The short version

Question	This book's answer
Two games	The speed game and the stay game
The speed game	Already decided at the starting line
The stay game	Everyone starts level. It counts from today
Why is it empty	It looks unappealing. Large capital doesn't come
Steady sellers are	Not planned — things that never disappeared

Question	This book's answer
The question to ask	Will I still be doing this in ten years
That kind of work	Not fun work — work that keeps nagging at you
Starting late means	Counts from today, starts small, and has read Part Two
If it doesn't come	Preparing and being in good shape are the same. Not wasted

◆ One Line Today

Last one. Write two things.

First, write down one thing you have **kept doing for more than ten years**.

It doesn't have to be work. A habit, a relationship, an interest. **Better if it's something people ask why you bother with.**

If there's nothing, that's an answer too. Move on.

Second, write down one thing you're doing now that you can answer this about.

Will I still be doing this in ten years?

If you wrote even one yes, **you are already inside the stay game.**

And the other nineteen chapters of this book were about how to make that one thing still be there in ten years.

If there's nothing to write yes about, that's the work in front of you. **Decide what you'll do for a long time before deciding what to make.**

Reverse that order and every method in this book stops working.

Closing — One Thing Still in Your Hands in Ten Years

◆ Back to five hundred and a thousand

Return to the two shops from the opening.

The one that opened five hundred in two years and had fewer seven months later, and the one that has sold one thing for a thousand years.

Both can now be described in this book's words.

The five hundred was on the fashion clock.

It sold talk. Talk decreases when used, and using it was selling it. And talk demand is a single nationwide quantity, divided by five hundred locations.

The leases outlasted the fad.

Not one bridge was laid. No reason to buy again, no shape to recognize, no property that improves with use, nothing to hand on.

The thousand years is sitting on the need clock.

There's a shrine in front, and people come to pray there. That flow doesn't grow and doesn't shrink. **It just changes people every year.**

The shop is standing at a door where demand renews.

And bridges are laid. The praying repeats, one item makes it easy to recognize, and twenty-five generations of making the same thing have accumulated a story.

Above all, the size was set.

Not entering department stores and not appearing at events isn't modesty. It's the calculation from Chapter 15.

**Small enough to sit through a quiet thousand years,
large enough to receive the days the worshippers**

come.

After twenty chapters you can write those two descriptions yourself. **That was the whole point.**

◆ **What this book never said**

One thing was left unsaid on purpose.

This book doesn't decide which one you want to be.

It didn't say earning a lot and finishing is bad. It didn't say earning a little for a long time is right.

Both hold up. Both are paid for.

What this book did was **show the price in advance.**

- Break out big and it's fast, and you don't know when it ends
- Go long and it doesn't go out, and the prize comes late or never

Which you pick is decided by your circumstances and your temperament. **Choosing without knowing and choosing knowing are different.**

Most of the people who opened those five hundred stores were probably diligent. **The missing piece wasn't diligence. It was a judgment about which clock they were on.**

◆ Twenty chapters in one sentence

Reduced:

Don't try to guess what will rise. Find what won't go, sit on it, and spend your time on not disappearing.

None of the three requires a special talent.

Guessing requires faster information than others. **Finding what won't go requires looking closely.** And not

disappearing requires only not quitting.

Which is why the last chapter is called "A Game That Favours Whoever Started Late."

◆ And the long one is hardest

Honestly: the third is the hardest of the three.

Told to wait ten years, nobody can. Waiting shaves a person down daily.

Chapter 15 redefined the problem.

**Not holding on while waiting for a wave, but
holding on in a state that doesn't require one.**

That thousand-year-old shop wasn't waiting a thousand years. **It grilled rice cakes, and each day turned on its own.**

Build a state that turns by itself, however small, and holding on stops being endurance. **It becomes just living.**

How to build it is in Parts Three and Six. And in that state, no wave is not a loss.

Findable. Recognizable. The story surviving. A body that can receive.

All four are simply a good state, wave or no wave.

◆ **One last thing to do**

Before closing the book, do exactly one thing.

Find the oldest object in your home.

Not the most expensive — the oldest. Over ten years is good; the oldest thing you have will do.

Hold it and write one line.

Why is this still here?

The answer will catch on one of four.

Because the time keeps coming around is Repeat.

Because it never occurred to you to change it is Shape.

Because it fits your hand better now is Patina. **Because somebody gave it to you** is Handoff.

It might be none of the four, and simply still here because it never got thrown away.

That's an answer too. And it's actually the answer closest to this book's conclusion.

◆ **And one more**

Ask the same question about your own work.

What will still be in my hands in ten years?

It's all right if no answer comes. Usually none does.

Knowing there's no answer is the first step to finding one.

And as Chapter 20 said, work you can answer yes about is not fun work.

It's work that keeps nagging at you.

The thing other people ask why you bother with, and you keep looking at anyway.

What that is differs for everyone, and nobody can decide it for you.

◆ What writing this book confirmed

One last thing.

Gather all the old things in this book and they have one trait in common.

Every one of them was new once.

The sign that looks worn now was a new sign at the start, and what gets called a classic was just a new release when it appeared.

That thousand-year-old shop had a first day too. The person who grilled the rice cakes that day didn't know about twenty-five generations.

Something old wasn't born special. It's something that didn't disappear while it was new.

The same is true of whatever you're making now. There's no way to know yet whether it will last.

But how to keep it from disappearing can be known.

And that method can start being used today.

That's all this book has to give, **and I think it's enough.**

How This Book Was Made

◆ **Why this book was especially risky**

There are real companies and real products in this book.
And it says why they rose and why they vanished.

That kind of account is unusually easy to invent.

Knowing the outcome, everything reads as though it had been foretold. The vanished ones show reasons to vanish; the survivors show reasons to survive.

Then line those reasons up and they overlap. **Traits the vanished ones also had are written down as the survivors' reasons.**

So three rules were set before starting.

◆ **Rule one · A number that couldn't be verified doesn't go in**

The same rule as the four books before this one.

Where a number was needed, the source that would settle it was written down first. Anything that ultimately couldn't be confirmed was **cut whole rather than reworded.**

This distinction matters.

Wrap it in "reportedly," "roughly," "at one point very," and the sentence survives. **And the reader takes it as fact.**

A hedged sentence isn't honesty. It's a transfer of responsibility.

◆ Rule two · Don't invent a cause after knowing the outcome

The hardest rule to keep in this book.

When something broke out is confirmable in records. Charts, revenue, store counts, visitor numbers. **Why it broke out is not confirmable.**

After it breaks out the explanations are abundant. Articles appear, analyses appear. Those explanations are almost all attached afterwards.

If several places had the same conditions at the same time and only one broke out, **those conditions are not the cause.**

So Part Five is written this way.

What happened is recorded. That it was the cause is not.

For a reader that can be frustrating. The frustration is what accuracy costs.

◆ Rule three · Don't count a trait the dead ones also had

The rule stated at the head of Part Three.

Look closely at survivors and too many things look like the reason. Good product, people loved it, luck held, the maker meant it.

Everything in Part Two was all of those things.

So those can't be the reason they split. Keeping this rule, what remained shrank hard, and what remained is the four bridges.

◆ The two chapters with no names

Chapters 13 and 15 contain no case names at all. Not from laziness — from the rules above.

Chapter 13. Things that sold little and had large influence attract dramatic anecdotes. Those anecdotes are well made, widely spread, and have no source.

Often a remark made in passing got repeated until it hardened into fact. Go looking and whoever said it first never had a basis either.

Widely known does not mean true.

Chapter 15. A chapter about what separates the ones that held on. Putting names in there means listing only the successes.

The number that met the same conditions and had nothing happen can't be counted. Listing only the successes without that number reverses the chapter's argument.

Both chapters keep the structure and drop the names. **The stories got flatter.** That was judged the better price to pay.

◆ **The limit of studying only survivors**

Chapter 4 wrote the empty box in the table first.

Things that didn't sell at the start and aren't here now. By count that box is overwhelmingly larger than the rest combined.

And nobody records it.

Nothing gets written about an object that failed to sell and disappeared. So this book was written by looking only at what survived and what got noticed.

That limit is repeated in each part. It was taken out once, knowing the repetition might be tiresome, and put back.

Say it once and the reader forgets it.

So this book says it this way.

Not "do this and it will last" but "the things that lasted had these in common."

The first is a guarantee, the second an observation. An observation raises the odds; a guarantee doesn't exist.

◆ Five things done to keep it from ageing

A book about steady sellers that goes stale in three years is a joke. So the rules were fixed before the writing.

One. "Lately," "recently" and "this year" were not used. "For a while" and "at some point" were used instead. Only expressions that stay true from the reader's position survived.

Two. Years almost never appear in the text. "Fifty years ago" doesn't go wrong as the reading year changes. Exact years are in each chapter's sources.

Three. Recent examples appear only in Part Two.

Where the subject is vanishing, a name going stale helps the argument.

Four. No generation labels. No term naming any generation was used. Those words age a book faster than anything else.

Five. Statistics give a direction only. "Rose," "fell," "reversed" instead of a percentage.

◆ How far the verification went

This is where it gets uncomfortable, so it goes in.

Cross-checking and verifying are different. Calling them by the same word means doing exactly what Chapter 13 warns against.

Anything that didn't contradict was recorded not as "confirmed" but as "**no evidence found that it's wrong.**"

◆ If something here is wrong

Something in here will be wrong. A source misread, a fact changed since, an interpretation pushed too far.

The Part Two cases especially may drift with time.

Something called vanished does sometimes come back.

That's the fourth path, covered in Part Five.

If that happens, the passage becomes wrong. And **because it's wrong in that particular way, the book's argument is proved at exactly that moment.**

If you find one, please say so. It goes into the next edition.

Not promising what can't be promised is also one of this book's rules.

Why Is This Still Here? ·